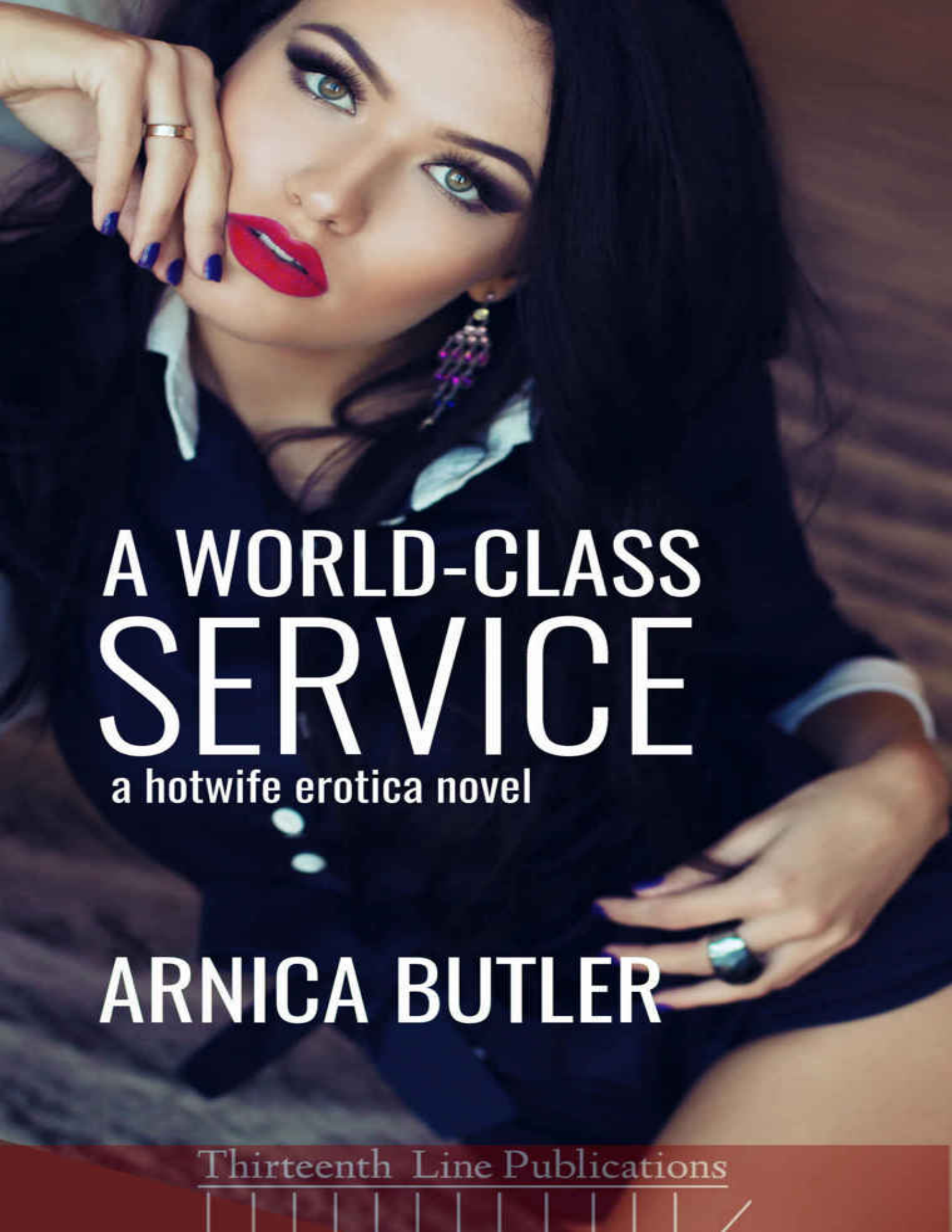




A WORLD-CLASS SERVICE

a hotwife erotica novel

ARNICA BUTLER

Thirteenth Line Publications

A WORLD-CLASS SERVICE
A Hotwife Erotica Novel
By Arnica Butler

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THANK YOU

To my BETA readers, whose tireless efforts make it possible to write in niche genres, and whose sharp eyes keep socks and commas in the right places, so my erotica is erotic (and not unintentionally comedic).

And of course, to my readers and fans. Thanks for supporting indie authors with purchases and reviews.

Enjoy!

1: AIRPORT HILTON

It's a mistake to be here.

For one thing, it's irresponsible as hell. My phone hasn't stopped buzzing since I got in the car and left the office at the totally inappropriate hour of 3:30pm. I've got a wrongful dismissal hearing tomorrow and a client on a domestic who can't keep himself out of trouble without constant check-ins.

Instead, I'm swiping through emails on an insecure network, walking through the dim belly of the airport Hilton, to where the bar is.

I crack my shin into a low-lying table because I'm not looking where I'm going. An attractive woman sitting on the couch gives me a snort and returns her gaze to her iPad.

"Goddammit," I seethe, still trying to finish the email I'm thumb-typing and get to the bar in time to have a drink to steady my nerves. If I slam a few now, I can sober up and be back at the office by 6:30.

With a little luck, I can still catch all the balls I just threw up in the air, in order to be here.

I scan the bar.

She's not here yet. The place is honestly pretty seedy. Sure, it's a Hilton, but it's got this dimly-lit, downstairs-basement bar vibe to it. A lot of transient people, eyeing each other over the lacquered u-shaped bar, getting wasted, sliding keys across the bar-top to each other with ring-bound fingers.

I sit down at the bar and order a whiskey. I change my mind and order a beer, which causes a flicker of recognition to gleam in the bartender's eyes. It's snuffed out easily enough: how many jittery married men does this guy serve booze to on any given day, after all?

Usually this place is good if you want to be left alone, and if I wasn't here for what I'm here for, I might have come here for just that. People hunker over their phones, spaced out two-to-three seats apart. Unless they're looking for a good time, in which case they scan the room, make eye contact, and then circle in.

You can go either way.

So when this guy plops down *next to me*, my first thought is that he's gay. He's gay and he's somehow mistaken me for gay. I'm so sure of it I almost open my mouth to tell him I'm not gay.

But he doesn't say anything to me, so I figure he's on the spectrum, or foreign (even though he doesn't look it, at all) which are the only two reasons I can think of for someone sitting next to you at a bar like this. (Other than being gay.)

He orders a Jack Daniels, so he's definitely not a gay man and I feel a little relieved, even if he is still sitting *right there* like a weirdo. I repress the urge to move over one seat and put some distance between us.

I scan the room one more time, my heart fluttering as the door to the downstairs lobby flashes in the corner of my eye.

I glance over: it isn't her.

I get back on my phone.

It's overflowing with emails, all of which are marked "urgent."

Jesus, what a job. What a job and I'm not paid nearly enough for it.

I remember when I went to an information session about being a lawyer *way* back in university. This guy came in and tried his darnedest to talk us out of it. *You're not going to be in a John Gresham novel, I remember him saying. You're going to be pushing a bunch of papers around or chasing ambulances. Some of you think you're gonna be a hot-shit lawyer in a big firm making millions a year while you play golf. Well, ask yourself if you know someone in a hot-shit law firm. No? Then you'll never get a job at one.*

At the end of that lovely speech, he said:

And don't, no matter what you do, go into employment or family law.

I'm not the finest listener.

My phone is ringing now. It's Cathy, the office assistant. She's on her third call now.

My thumb hovers over the icon for answering the call.

Dammit.

"Yeah, Cathy," I say, curtly as I can. *I don't want to take this call*, my tone says. *So make it quick.*

"I know," Cathy says dryly.

She knows all right. Cathy knows: I don't want to talk to her or be interrupted. She knows: I am not going to fucking believe this, but... She

knows: we all should have chosen a different career path and would, if we could go back in time and do just that.

I wait.

“It’s Craig Martin.”

“Mar-teen,” I correct her. “Jesus, what?”

“His sister can’t find him. Thinks he’s done a runner.”

I put my hand to my face. These fucking people.

“You want me to call Terry?” she continues.

I pause.

“What’s he out on?” I say finally.

“I think it’s \$10K.” Cathy waits. “It’s a lot of money to the sister, Colt.”

Fuck, Cathy, who do you think I am? \$10K is a lot of money to *me*. Of course, Terry’s not cheap either. And I’ll never get that money back.

I lift my eyes, and a jolt goes through me.

She’s here.

I babble. “Yeah, call Terry I guess. Ugh. Fuck. Call Terry and then... I don’t know. I’ll be back around 6:30 to deal with this.”

“Yep.”

Cathy asks no questions, and she tells you no lies.

“Jesus,” the guy next to me says.

I set my phone face down on the bar and reach for my beer as I watch her enter the bar.

She’s with some friends, it seems.

They’re coming over to the opposite side of the bar.

“Who do you think she works for?” the guy says. “Swedish?”

I look at the woman he’s talking about. She’s tall, and her blonde hair has that white-ish, natural sheen to it that can’t be bottled. Ice-blue eyes, a straight mouth. Under the polyester uniform, bountiful curves at the breast and hip level.

“Not Swedish,” I say. “Wrong uniform.”

The guy is raking over her with his eyes. “You think she’s one of the good ones?”

“Heh,” I say, noncommittally.

I know what he thinks he’s talking about: the oft-repeated rumor that all the flight attendants of the world are one-night-standing their way

through every stop.

The blonde is hot, and being honest, she looks like a good time. She's ordering a drink, and she's doing it in uniform, which is pretty flippant but she's a corporate attendant and they're a lot more lax.

Or so I hear.

But I'm waiting for something else. Any minute now, this guy's going to take in the rest of the scene.

The blonde is with a man, who is also wearing a uniform but seems like the chef variety. And a brown-haired woman in a different uniform altogether. She's wearing a plain white blouse with the top button undone, a loosened necktie slouching sexily over the curve of her small breasts, a black skirt hugging her thin figure.

The guy leans closer to me, but keeps his eyes on the blonde.

"You ever joined the mile-high club?" he asks.

"Depends how you mean," I quip. "Once I had sex in Denver."

This makes the guy laugh, and he sinks for a minute into his own thoughts. "I know for a fact those ladies put out." And then it hits him. His eyes shift.

"That one, there? She's a corporate stewardess. And you know they're up for it."

"Hmm," I say.

Now he's looking at the brunette. I can tell because he's speaking slower. It's like a sunrise is happening in his head.

She's not the first girl anyone looks at, ever, I've noticed. She doesn't have white-blond hair or a huge rack. She doesn't do a lot to call attention to herself.

But then you notice her. Maybe because she's quietly looking at everything, with a little grin that you can't quite see on her face. She's amused by most things, smarter than most people, and she wears that expression on her face without actually wearing it. She has a secret, and she'll probably never tell you what it is.

Her eyes are blue-green, too. A very special shade that you see on no one else, a shade that's more for cats than women. Once you notice that, they pop out and her brown hair doesn't seem so plain. She has her hair piled up on her head, but a lot of loose wisps tease at what it might all look like down: thick. Wavy. A little hard to pin down, like her.

Her features are all sort of plain, except for her mouth. Her upper lip is just slightly fuller than her lower, and curves on the sides steeply, making almost a wave crest. It's an unusual mouth, one you don't see on just anyone.

She's stirring Stivia into her iced tea, looking down at it, a little smile on her lips. Her eyelashes are long and she has an aura about her that reminds you of the bedroom. She's listening in – listening in on everything.

The guy next to me has noticed her.

She's eclipsed the blonde in his eyes. The lanky brunette is sucking him in.

And then, suddenly, she lifts her eyes, and stares right at him.

It gives me a jolt, and she isn't even looking at me. I glance over at Mr. Mile High, and I see she's frozen him dead-cold in his seat. He isn't even breathing.

The guy lifts a hand to the bartender. "Hey," he says. "Will you get that girl a drink? What's she drinking?"

The bartender looks back. His thoughts, too, go where everyone's go first. "The blonde?" He's so sure that it *is* the blonde that he turns around, swipes up some condensation from the bar, and says, "Rum and Coke."

"No," the guy says, still deep in the bubble of this woman's stare. "The other one, the brunette."

The bartender raises his eyebrows. He's a guy who hears a lot of things, his face says, but it's *always* the hot blonde.

He turns back to look at the woman, who evidently is also there and merits a drink over the buxom Swede.

I can see the bartender crumble. The same way the guy next to me did. Confused at first, then like magic, sucked in.

"Uh..."

He walks over to the brunette.

Across the bar, the brunette picks up her glass, bringing a straw to her lips and closing that magnificent mouth around it in an unmistakable allusion to sucking on a man's cock. Her eyes are still on the guy, freezing him out, pulling him in, seducing and leveling, all at the same time. She leans backward playfully, hanging onto the brass rail on the perimeter of the bar, and swings a little from left to right. Her feet are on the rail at the bottom.

She's nymph-like as she does this, and suddenly the buxom blonde seems too bright, too large, too perfectly formed.

Also, the blonde is missing something.

But not the brunette.

The nymph says something to the bartender, drops her feet to the floor, and comes floating, floating around the bar. She has her eyes on the guy next to me the whole time.

The bartender watches her as she goes.

And then she's behind us. I can feel her energy, it's raising all the hair on the back of my neck.

"I'm on call," she says. Her voice is as lark-like as you would expect, like shards of light. A vague, sexy nasality to it, like she has the mildest of colds. "So I'm drinking iced tea."

The guys spins around in his chair, and I can't help looking over my shoulder.

"But that doesn't mean I'm not up for a good time," she says.

I stare as she reaches forward and puts her hand on the guy's knee. He's so stunned all he can do is stare at her, his mouth hanging open.

I'm stunned, too, and now I'm staring openly.

She leans forward, her lithe torso stretching out in front of me, her blouse pulling away from the neat skirt, like it might come out any moment and show me her smooth skin. She puts her hands on the back of his neck, and brings her puffy lips to his ear.

She whispers something, and chills go through me. I turn back to my phone, pretending like I'm deeply into something, but I'm straining to see her mouth moving as she talks to him, or hear what she's rasping in his ear.

The guy pulls back, looks at her for a moment, and then gets up out of his seat. He leaves.

She watches him, chewing slightly on the end of the straw, before she plops into his chair and pushes his beer out of the way.

"Hey," she says.

As I often find, I'm unable to speak to my own wife.

"Are you... what did you tell that guy?" I babble.

Brooke swings her long lashes along with her eyes in a dramatic sweep to look over her shoulder without turning much. Her mouth is open, wet and red. Today she's wearing a pink lip gloss with a dark red stain in the center of her plump lips. It makes them look bigger, makes her look

younger. “That guy,” she says, her voice bored and knowledgeable. “He’s married. He’s going to make a run for it once he gets to the lobby.”

We turn our eyes to the lobby, where Mile-High is, indeed, looking like he’s going to make a run for it.

“There he goes,” Brooke says triumphantly, as he turns abruptly and rushes through the door in an unsightly fast-walk. She turns her attention back to me. “Did he walk out on his bill?” she asks incredulously. “Sooo tacky.”

“I’ll pay it,” I say quickly. “But what did you *say*?”

My wife leans toward me and puts her hands on my knees. She rises up a little out of her seat to get her mouth close to my ear. “I said: go get a room and five hundred dollars cash, and I’ll show you a trick I picked up in Montserrat.”

Brooke fell back into her seat. “Then I licked his earlobe,” she said cheerfully. “Just for good measure.”

My cock is hard as a rock.

She didn’t lick his earlobe, just to be clear.

Or at least, I’m pretty sure she didn’t.

She turns to me and rests her cheek on her hand. “Thanks for coming on such short notice.”

“Anything for you,” I say.

Brooke puts her fingers to her lips and bites on the ends of them, only making my condition worse.

The blonde is leaving. She lifts a hand and calls out. “Bye, bye, Brooke.”

It would seem she does, in fact, have a Swedish accent.

“She Swedish?” I ask.

Brooke rolls her eyes. “Oh, God, if I had twenty dollars for every time someone *asked* me that.” She leans forward and bites her straw again.

Then she quips: “I’d have eighty dollars.”

A lot of people might wonder how it is that I got this woman to marry me, and if they do, they’re in the same boat with me, myself and I. Brooke is smart, her wit is acerbic, she’s a cool customer, and she’s sexy as hell – once you notice her.

Which everyone always does, eventually.

Brooke turns to me suddenly, her eyes lighting up with the other aspect of her personality I’m a little less comfortable with. In addition to

being witty, smart, and ethereally beautiful, Brooke is also: impulsive, wild, and sometimes dangerous.

“I don’t have time to get a room and stuff,” she says, her voice breathy and seductive, but also matter-of-fact. She puts her hand on my thigh and slides it along my muscle, until her fingertips brush over the tip of my cock.

So what if I’m a lawyer and I could get disbarred for public indecency? Which is what I’m pretty sure Brooke is about to suggest, in one form or another. So what if I’m letting one of my clients escape bail and not preparing for trial for another because I’d rather see what Brooke is going to do – or rather, *hear* what Brooke has to say – in a car or a bathroom at the airport Hilton?

“You have your car?” she asks, one hand tracing the shape of my cock over the fabric of my suit, the other playing with the edge of her blouse. In the open plunge of her neckline, I can see her white bra, lacy and brand-new-looking, hugging her handful of perfect breasts to her chest.

Car it is. I fish the keys out of my pocket and Brooke slips off the stool. “Don’t forget to pay the bill,” she says, not looking back.

*

I parked in the airport parking structure, for the low low price of fifteen dollars an hour. We take a shuttle the short distance to the airport, and Brooke rides like a pro, barely holding onto the rail. She has a small carry-on rolling suitcase, and this too, she barely pays any mind. Occasionally, she looks at me with her black lashes and gives me a searing look.

The car is on the roof and we get in. “I better go to the basement,” I say.

Brooke shrugs and looks around. “This should be okay,” she says. She slips her hand into my pants and her fingers close around my cock. “Let’s just get in the back.”

I have tinted windows, but still. I should say something, but Brooke is already opening the door, getting out, headed to the back seat.

With our schedules, it will probably be a week before I see her at a time when we can do this.

So, my mouth hanging open in disapproval, I get out and get in the back of the car.

My wife is already sliding her panties down her long legs, pulling her feet neatly through them without even taking off her shoes. Heels, not impractically high, but sexy nonetheless. Especially because she doesn't ever seem to feel the need to take them off.

I unbuckle my belt, watching her, wondering what she has in mind.

She unclips her hair and shakes it out. It's wavy and looks wild when she unleashes it, which is a handy metaphor for her personality. She scoots her dress up and hops onto my lap in one easy, practiced motion.

I have my hand ready and waiting for her, for the smooth, always waxed softness of her pussy. I cup the lips of her slit in my hand, enjoying the silky feel of her flesh, and she pushes against my hand. Her lips spread out, parting around my fingers, and the wetness inside of them spills out like an overripe fruit.

I can smell her now, the tangy-sweet scent of her, laced with coffee today. (Brooke will sometimes drink six strong coffees in a row, in less than an hour.) It's a peculiar habit, one that comes through her skin faintly and sweetly, giving me a rather perverse reaction to the smell of freshly-brewed coffee.

I slip my fingers into her pussy and seek out her hard clit. She's incredibly wet, ready to go, and as usual even though this is all a game, a part of me wonders if it really is. Do I have my fingers in Brooke's pussy, wet and sticky from only her arousal? Or have I plunged my fingers into her cheating cunt to get them slick with the cum of another man?

"You're so wet," I say.

Brooke moves her hand to my zipper and frees my cock with more expert movements that further inspire my imagination – why is she so very good, so very practiced, at getting a man's cock out in a small, confined space?

"You wouldn't believe who we flew with last night," she breathed close to my neck. "He's someone *very* famous. And his whole entourage was with him."

She's made the words "whole entourage" about as delicious as she can, rolling them around in her mouth so that they get as much weight as possible.

My cock is pointed straight up, throbbing, and Brooke has risen to her knees, bending a little against the ceiling. She's looking down at me, her eyes lit up with excitement. Her hand is on my cock, and she guides it to her opening. The hot, sticky lips of her cunt close around the tip of me, and I grunt involuntarily.

She moves her hips to drag the tip of my shaft through the slick crevices of her cunt. "And of course, I did them *all*."

My cock pulses in her hand, and she grins.

"I got my pussy all filled with a lot of hot, basketball-player cum. You want to feel?"

I make a sound that means 'yes.'

She slides onto my cock and I sink into her hot flesh. Part of me is actually trying to sense whether or not her pussy is looser, whether or not she might have all these purported loads of cum inside of her.

I grab her ass, fingers digging into her flesh, and she rides me hard. Her hair gets sweaty and starts to curl a little near her hairline. Her eyes get glassy and distant, and I have to wonder if she isn't thinking about her basketball player and his entourage – whether she did actually fuck them or not.

Is she thinking about how much she'd *like* to have fucked them?

I'm getting close, which hasn't taken much, when I feel Brooke's pussy quiver around my cock and then burst into spasms of hot liquid.

"Oh God," I say, and I'm so close to going over the edge.

Brooke surprises me then by hopping off of my cock. I'm so shocked, gripped by how close I was to going over the edge, that I just stare at her in horror.

"Can't go see my next client all full of cum," she says wickedly. And then she scoots back and takes my cock, slick with her juices, into her hand.

Brooke's mouth makes short work of sucking me off, and I come in her mouth. She sucks the cum right out of me, and swirls her tongue around my shaft while she makes her way up to the tip. She releases me with a pop, and runs her tongue along her lower lip as she looks at me. Not a trace of mess or cum in her mouth. She brings a finger to the corner of her mouth anyway, and grins.

I suddenly realize where we are, and I look around frantically. I'm relieved when I see that there is no parking security staring at us, no old

woman who is scandalized and about to call security on us, and nothing else that might end in a huge spectacle.

Brooke is putting on her panties, stepping into the pristine white lace one leg hole at a time, her heels still on. She scoots them up her thighs and straightens out her skirt, then buttons her blouse right up to the neck and fixes the tie she wears.

I have all kinds of dirty thoughts about that tie, and they wash ashore on my face as what I'm sure is a purely lecherous expression. Brooke sees it, even if she isn't looking at me, and grins. Brooke has a dirtier mind than I do, so I'm sure she's picked up on at least the direction of my thoughts.

"I have to go," she purrs, turning toward me. She is fastening her hair back up into her professional but sexy twist. She leans forward to bite my lip, and the faintest trace of the scent of her pussy clings to my lips. "I'll be back in two days."

"Who are you going with this time?" I say.

Brooke shrugs. "Some business guy. New."

She leans over to me and slides her hand down my thigh. "I promise to tell you *all* about it."

Then she gets out of the car, opens the front door, and pulls her wheely cart out. "Bye," she says. "I love you."

I watch her walk away, her small but well-formed ass moving sensually in the fitted skirt of her uniform. Brooke walks like she's on a catwalk, one foot in front of the other. She does it effortlessly, so it doesn't look silly, just hot. It makes her heels click just so.

When she disappears, I turn and look at my reflection in the rear-view mirror.

The sense of unease that I have with this whole situation returns. My stomach gets cold, and my balls contract until they ache.

It's all just a game we play, I remind myself. I lift my fingers to my nose. There's nothing to the scent on my hand except the smell of Brooke: tangy-sweet and tainted with her coffee habit.

She didn't get her pussy filled up with the cum of a basketball player and his entourage.

Nor had she really just climbed off of me because she didn't want her pussy filled up with cum because she planned to have sex on the plane. She just didn't want cum dripping down her leg while she worked.

"*Right*," I say aloud, just to make myself feel better.

2: SIX MONTHS AGO

I slid my fingers under Brooke's starched skirt, the unyielding polyester fabric raking over my skin. My fingers searched for the hem of her nylons, and my mouth grazed over her neck. Her hair was still put up in her in-flight twist, but strands of it had fallen loose and grazed my cheeks and my nose.

Brooke squirmed as I hiked her skirt up and my fingers floated over her skin. Regulations required her to wear a pair of nylons, and they couldn't be the attractive thigh-high ones. I found the hem of her hose and pulled it down, peeling her like a fruit.

I sort of liked the pantyhose: I liked to pull them down to just below her ass and look at the scene, vaguely bondage-like, her small butt swelling out of the nylons as though it had become that shape just for me.

Brooke was standing up against a wall, her hands pressed against it. Her underwear – unregulated – was a thong, nestled between the two tight spheres of her bottom and cresting over the shape of her hips. In front, though I couldn't see it now, I knew the panties were lace. The embroidered pattern was thick near her pelvis and then disintegrated into a transparent fabric as it passed over her mound. Her bare pussy, smooth like the rest of her porcelain skin, was visible through the material as nothing more than a thin pink gash.

I slipped a finger under the silky fabric that ran between her buttocks, and teased her with a feathery touch from the base of her spine, over her tight eyelet, and into the soft pink flesh that had welled up with excitement. She turned her head slightly, exhaling.

"I was pouring some champagne in the galley," she breathed. "And he came up behind me out of nowhere. He stood right behind me, not really touching me, but, you know, I could feel him anyway. All that muscle, how hard his body was. I mean, he's a professional athlete right? And then, out of nowhere, he reaches his arm forward and takes one of the glasses of champagne. And I just stare at his arm, because it's so big, it's like, *this* thick." Brooke brought her hands together to indicate the girth of Jerian Caruso's arm, as if she needed to. I'd seen pictures of the veined and tattooed slabs of meat that extended from his shoulders.

My cock was already thick and pulsing, ready to plunge inside of her. But I liked to draw it out when she came home from a trip. Especially when she was fresh off the plane, still smelling of the cabin. Especially when I could imagine that if I dipped my fingers into her cunt I might find it slick with another man's cum, or stretched by his big cock. I moved a finger to find her clit and she shuddered as I played with it, teasing the button with a soft flick. "Keep talking," I whispered into her neck.

"And so, I was... um..."

Brooke was as turned on as I was, and she was losing her train of thought. As far as I knew, Caruso really was on the flight, and maybe he even *had* come up behind her just like she was saying.

"And then, he moved forward, and his whole body was along my back..."

At this point, Brooke's pussy seemed to gush open. The slick juices of her arousal welled up and slid onto my fingers, down her thighs. The scent of her pussy filled the air.

I pushed two fingers into her pussy, partly to feel inside of her. To test the veracity of this story.

"Mmm," she murmured. "And so... and then... he was like, 'I need a little bit of help with something.'"

I leaned my head against the back of Brooke's as a sweetly poisonous ache seized my stomach.

Brooke's pussy shuddered around my fingers.

"What did you do?" I said, knowing that her answer would be something filthy.

"Well," Brooke said coyly, her eyelashes fluttering up and off of her cheeks. Her mouth was parted and her breath a little ragged. "It's my job to help out. So I said I was at his service."

My cock pulsed and I actually felt a bead of precum boil out of it.

"He told me he just needed a little bit of relaxation, because he was afraid of flying. Then he went into the lavatory. And of course I followed him."

I just kept breathing into her neck, spreading my fingers out inside of her to stroke the root of her clit and make her buck against me.

"It was really hard," she breathed. "We almost didn't fit. But then... we managed to get in there... and of course it's the easiest thing for me to

just sit down. But he was so tall that... um... once he took his cock out of his jeans, it was over the top of my face when I was looking up....”

I had my own cock out by then, so Brooke felt it as it thumped hard against her inner thigh. I could feel the sticky juices of her pussy along the length of my shaft. I pulled my fingers out of her and brought them up to her shoulder, ready for the next part of her story.

“And so I just had to lick him all along the length of his cock. That was all I could do with my mouth. So he started rubbing it over my lips, all the way to his balls. And then... I couldn’t... get it... so he put his balls in my mouth and he grabbed his own shaft and started to jerk off right above my face...”

Brooke turned her head to the side, and I slid my fingers into her mouth. She sucked on them, sucking off her pussy juices. I found her dripping hole and pushed my own cock inside of her. She pushed back to get into a better position, and I started to fuck her while she sucked on my fingers.

I felt Brooke’s pussy clenching around my cock. She turned her face to the wall and leaned her forehead against it, my fingers sliding out of her mouth. She pushed back to get better traction as I started to fuck her hard. Her forehead thumped lightly into the wall as I hammered her.

“Oh! Oh!” Brooke yelled.

“And then what, you little slut?” I growled, fucking her forcefully right through her climax and beyond.

“And then, and then... he came all over my face... and I... I...”

It was too late, I was already coming.

One time, Brooke had invented a story very similar to this one (but without the NFL star), and at the end he had come all over her face. She had ended that story with another flight attendant being summoned to come in and lick the cum from her lips and cheeks with her long pink tongue.

I exploded inside of her and then we panted together against the wall.

This was all fake, of course, but each time that Brooke told me a story like that, her attention to detail was so... good... that I had to wonder how much of it was just invention and fantasy. Jerian Caruso had really been on her flight, I had no doubt of that. Had he talked to her? Had he asked for help? Had she really replied that she was at his service? How far had things actually gone?

Brooke shifted and my cock flopped out of her pussy. I pushed away from the wall, and she pushed her hair back into place.

She shimmied out of the pantyhose but pulled up her underwear. She loosened her blouse, which had somehow made it through the ordeal without being untucked. Then she smiled and headed into the kitchen. “Want a drink?” she asked me, as I collapsed into a chair.

We were in the living room because we had been unable to make it any further into the house.

I heard dishes and glasses clattering around in the kitchen. Brooke returned, and she had a strange smile on her lips.

“So listen,” she said to me. She slinked toward me and curled up in my lap, moving with long, feline stretches. “I want to run something past you.”

She had poured me a glass of wine and I took it, feeling, as I always did with Brooke, a little excited and a little wary. She was unpredictable.

She bit her lower lip. “I got a job offer today,” she said. She shifted on my lap, and her lean thighs ground into mine. Her bottom sank into my crotch, rubbing my cock. Above the scent of sex, she smelled like lilies and lavender, clean and silky.

Intoxicated by all that, it took me a moment to respond. “A-huh.” I said, inhaling the scent of her skin at her neck. I was already feeling aroused again.

She smiled. “Do you... want to know what it is?” she asked.

Brooke didn’t mind when my mind sunk into sex mode and I didn’t listen to her. In fact, I think she rather liked it. I was still deep in my thoughts about Caruso and the long-ago invented story of the licking colleague.

I scanned my mind to figure out what Brooke was talking about *then*.

“Oh,” I said hastily.

Ah, yes. A job offer.

“What is it?” I asked.

Now I craned back from her face to look at her. This *was* interesting, now that it was reaching my consciousness.

Brooke curled up tighter in my lap, clutching her ankles to her thighs. Her eyes lit up with excitement. “So I was on my regular flight, and this guy got really irate about... I don’t know what. His food or something. So I took care of the problem and got him calmed down....”

My mind wandered a little. It was sort of disappointing to hear that this was all that had happened on Brooke's flight. Angry first-class passengers instead of lusty, brazen NFL players.

"...and then this *other* guy, who was sitting in the back and had this, I don't know, look about him like he didn't really belong there -"

"Like he didn't belong in first class?"

I said this mostly to indicate that I was listening intently. My mind was still miles away, envisioning the story she'd just told me.

"Yeah, but like... not because he belonged in coach. This guy was more like... he shouldn't be on a commercial flight, you know?"

I did not know, but I nodded anyway. Brooke sized people up in a heartbeat, based on their watch or their shoes, or the way they ate. She knew if you belonged in first class or you had put it all on your credit card for a thrill you'd be paying off forever.

Or, though this was rare, if you were slumming it.

"So *this* guy," she said, to get me back on track with the story.

"The more-than-first-class-guy," I murmured. I was mostly thinking about the feel of her bottom against my thickening cock, the swell of her breasts in the blouse she was wearing, and how she was going to taste when I pulled her thighs apart and licked her pussy later.

"Yeah. He says, 'Have you ever thought of leaving the commercial airline industry?'" She lowered her voice to imitate the man.

I raised my eyebrows, my interest sucked back to the conversation. "And?"

"And he hands me this card, flip," she mimicked the way the man flipped his card at her, "like out of the movies. He says, 'I'm recruiting high-caliber flight attendants for Groshing... Grosic... Grodnick... anyway, this company, and you have exactly what we're looking for. Salaries start around eighty thousand.'"

This caught my attention. I opened my eyes wide in disbelief.

"Dollars?"

"That was *my* first question. So at first I look at this card like this guy's selling me Gucci for \$50, right? And I'm like... okay... and I pocket the card. Then I humor him a little, because, you know, I'm a professional."

Brooke squirmed on my lap and leaned in close to my face. "Then," she said conspiratorially. "I'm in the front getting a drink, and I tell this guy John about it – you know the gay guy you thought I was sleeping with?"

I did remember.

“And he *loses his shit*. He actually loses it. He’s heard of this place, and these people, and he says that some of them make like \$100K, maybe more. Flying like 400 hours a year or something. He practically shoved me out there again. He says,” and here her eyes really lit up, “that he met this gal who worked for the same company who made a ten thousand dollar tip.”

My head was spinning.

Of course I had gone to the most obvious place, the place where all men’s minds go if someone talks about a corporate flight attendant making \$100K a year.

It must be for sex.

Unfortunately, all Brooke could feel was how much it aroused me, and so she got the coy smile going and ground her bottom against my cock. “I know,” she said. Agreeing to what, I didn’t know.

“So what happened?” I said.

“Well, I tracked the guy down at the train, and I got in next to him. Then I told him I had been so weird on the plane out of professionalism, and I asked him for an interview.”

“And?”

Brooke bit her thumb and grinned. “Well, he gave me one right then and there.”

My cock throbbed.

Brooke was playing with me, I was almost 75% sure. She slid off my lap and onto her knees, grinning at me as she did. “And *I*,” she said theatrically, “gave the performance of a lifetime.”

I was speechless for a moment.

And then I decided that she must be joking.

The whole entire thing was another fantasy piece. It was strange that she’d do it so soon, strange that she was this horny... but who was I to argue?

“The performance of a lifetime, huh?” I said, to play along. “Show me what you did.”

“I’ll show you what I did,” she teased. “And then you tell me if you think I got the job or not.”

She let her mischievous eyes simmer at me for a moment, and I had a time deciding where to look: her smokey bedroom eyes, or her lips, where

she was running her tongue seductively.

She grasped my cock in one hand and leaned forward, her eyes on mine. Her lips were slightly parted as she brought the crown of my cock to them. She rubbed the glistening head of my dick over the soft red flesh, smearing the bead of precum that had boiled up from inside me over her sensual upper lip. Then she brought her tongue up to to lick it off, the back of it rolling over the ridge of my head.

Her tongue darted down, making a swirl around the crown of my dick, wet and delicious. Her mouth was open and her breath was tantalizing, but she was only teasing me with the promise of taking my shaft inside of it. She made another pass around the circumference of my cock with her tongue, her mouth smiling a little. She squeezed my shaft, and stroked me slowly, until another bead of precum bubbled up on my head.

This time, she licked it away with a quick flick of her tongue.

“This guy had a *huge* cock,” she said, and my own dick throbbed in her hand, so she smiled. “It was so hard to get the whole thing in my mouth. But I really wanted that job, so I knew I had to do it.” She was talking right next to the tip of my dick, her hot breath caressing my skin and making me halfway sick with desire. “I had to get the whole thing in, all the way down my throat, so I could get my tongue out to lick his balls. Do you want to see what I did?”

She cocked her head to the side, as though she were genuinely curious *if* I would like to see what she did.

Then she looked at my cock as she stroked it, like she was trying to size it up.

She opened her mouth, gave me one last simmering look, and started to feed my meat into her lips.

My cock was swallowed up in the hot, silky interior of her mouth. Brooke had always had a talent for blowjobs – it’s like her teeth disappeared. Her lips slid down, and down, and down.

I’m not a huge guy, so it was never hard for her to get to the base of my cock. I shuddered, almost unable to control myself.

There was a wave of muscle in her mouth, rolling over my cock, and then I tipped my head back and gasped at the ceiling. I almost couldn’t believe what I was feeling, as her tongue emerged from between my cock and her lips, and slid down my balls. Then she started to wag it back and forth over my scrotum.

The filthy sound this made was the only thing in the room, a gagging slurp. I looked down, and could only see the top of her head and her stretched lips.

Then the filthy way she had claimed to do this to the man from the plane surfaced in my mind and I clutched her hair, pulling back gently to let her know I was about to come. Not that it mattered to her most of the time: usually Brooke was willing to swallow if she'd gone this far. She was a pretty filthy girl in bed, which was something I loved about her.

"Brooke," I said, and she swept her tongue over my balls again.

That was it: I came with a yell and filled her mouth with cum. She sucked it out of me like she was sucking marrow from a bone, pulling her mouth from my dick as she did. A wet smacking sound signaled the end of her blowjob.

"So I got the job," she said.

I just stared down at her, my mouth open in shock.

The thing was, it was so *hot* when Brooke did this sort of thing, that I just let it all happen.

Then later, I was never quite sure where reality left off and fantasy began.

I suppose I liked that feeling of not knowing.

But as the effects of my climax began to wear off, I gave what she said some more thought.

Real thought, not sex-drenched thought.

"So," I said, after a while. "You didn't actually take this job, did you?"

Brooke looked at me incredulously. "Did you hear what I said?" she asked. "It's a raise of like \$40K a year." Then she smiled devilishly. "Plus *tips*."

A cold sensation washed over me. This was real?

The job offer was real, even if the blowjob to get it was not.

Or at least, I hoped not.

This game had started a few years before when I had confided to Brooke one drunken evening that it sort of turned me on thinking about all the men who were hitting on her on the plane. Since then, it had snowballed into the dirty talk that we had going on in bed, and Brooke always seemed to be ready to take it (the dirty *talk*) to the next level.

It was my understanding, though – and I had no reason to doubt this – that this is all it was: just talk.

Still, it burned when she said things like this, because she said them with such relish. After sex. Kind of like she was daring me to call her out on whether or not she intended to actually make “tips” in that price range or not.

A flash of frustration crept over my cheekbones and my skin got hot. “Brooke, I’m being serious here. You didn’t actually take it, right?”

Brooke slipped her blouse over her head, revealing her lacy bra. It was white, made of a thin material that let the dark pink of her nipples wink right through it. Her nipples were pebbled, little round dots in the center of her small, perfect breasts. “Uh... I *am* serious,” she said. She shook her hair out and then started to capture it back up into a loose ponytail. “This is a once-in-a-lifetime opportunity.”

“Without talking to me,” I said, getting out of the slouched position I had been in.

Brooke’s face fell a little. Then she stood up, turned to me, and played with my knees with her own, knocking them about playfully, biting on her lower lip. “Oh come on,” she said. “It’s perfect. I’ll make a whack of cash, quit in two years, and then I can go back to school for... whatever... with no debt.”

I was frowning.

“I can be your sugar-momma,” she teased.

I frowned even more. Call me old-fashioned, but I didn’t like the idea of my wife making more money than me. And while this game we played was fun, “corporate flight attendant” had connotations that were just a little too much for me. All of this was going through my head at light-speed, of course, because she’d just dropped this on me out of the blue.

“Oh come on,” Brooke said, leaning down to kiss me. She dropped her voice. “It will be so much fun for our little game.”

If I hadn’t just come twice, this would have made my cock react instantaneously.

I narrowed my eyes instead. “Brooke, just hold on for a second,” I said, needing clarification. Desperately. “Stop playing games, and answer me seriously, okay?”

“Okay,” she said, but she had that damn little smile on her lips.

I shifted in the chair and leaned on my knees. “Brooke, for serious. Totally serious, please.”

She closed her eyes slowly and made a cross over her heart.

“Brooke,” I said exasperated.

She opened her eyes and grinned. Then she slapped me playfully on the knee. “Okay. Jeez. Serious. Totally. Shoot.”

I eyed her warily. She did seem to finally be serious.

“You actually took a job, as a corporate flight attendant.”

Brooke lowered her forehead, keeping her eyes on mine, as I asked the question. I started to get a choking feeling in my chest because I thought she was fucking with me again.

“No,” she said cheerfully. “I did, however, get a job *offer*. And it is, actually, \$100K a year. And I am, obviously, going to accept it. Right after I talk to you about it.”

I really, really wanted to clarify that she had not sucked this guy’s cock (and while I was at it, perhaps clarify that she hadn’t let Jerian Caruso spray cum all over her face), but I didn’t want to look as insecure as I felt.

My mouth fell open.

“It’s actually \$100K?” I said.

This was more than I made.

Actually, quite a bit more than I made.

“What kind of hours are those?” I said.

Brooke squealed. “That’s the best part,” she said. “He put me in touch with this other woman who worked for them, like as soon as we were at the airport -”

“Wait... what?”

Brooke waved her hand at me. “She was on the train. Anyway, she said she worked like 400 hours last year. And made \$120K. *And* got a five-thousand dollar tip once.”

Brooke raised her eyebrows.

“A five-thousand dollar tip,” I said. “For what, I wonder?”

Brooke raised her eyebrows. She took a glass of wine she had set on the table next to me and took a sip of it. “Anyway, the hours are shitty, and you’re on call all the time... but who cares? I’ll do this for a few years, save all the money, and then I can go back to school.” She gulped some wine.

I stared at her. “Well... I mean, were you planning on *asking* me?”

Brooke held the wine glass above her knee and crossed her legs. She was sitting on the arm of the couch. She looked at me archly.

I wasn't sure if she was going to explode or not.

But she just fell to her feet, and leaned over to kiss me. "You aren't the boss of me," she said, triggering a strangely erotic shiver through me. "But even if you were, you know this deal is too good to pass up. So yes, I'm 'asking you,'" she made air-quotes. "But we all know what you'll say."

She slinked away. "I'm getting more wine. To celebrate."

I sat in the chair. She was right, of course: there was no logical reason to turn this job down.

But every *illogical* reason in the world.

"You're going to lose your seniority," I warned.

Brooke snorted so loudly I could hear her from the kitchen. "And get three times the pay. How tragic."

I stared at the wall, my mind on fire.

"But you won't be soliciting any huge tips, right?" I called out to her.

I hoped it sounded "jokey." I wanted it to. I wanted to trust my wife so completely that it didn't bother me if she got a job as a corporate flight attendant and spent weeks away from home in exotic locations making more money than me and "servicing" billionaires.

I wanted that to be the case, but of course it wasn't.

Brooke, however, took it as a "jokey" statement, and she was beaming when she leaned her head out of the kitchen. "I knew you'd be on board," she said jovially.

"I'm all buckled in," I said glumly.

She brought the wine out and clinked her glass to mine.

"All systems go," I said dryly. "Ready for takeoff."

Brooke rolled her eyes, but appreciatively.

And then we finished off a bottle of wine and had sex again. The whole time I was thinking about her blowjob stories and wondering if they were real.

When I slept that night, it was richly depraved sleep and one of my dreams consisted of Brooke running off with a billionaire just days after starting her job.

In the end, she accepted the job and started flying for Gronner Inc. about a month later.

*

So here we are. Brooke has no discernible schedule; she can be called to fly almost any time of day or night. It's unfair of me to be grouchy about that, because that's the kind of schedule I've been maintaining for years. Brooke has also pointed out that she's had to practically stop drinking. And there's no way arguing against the fact that the job has been a financial boon for us.

But it also means that a lot of our relationship has been reduced to meetings like the one in the airport parking lot. More like a series of hook-ups, or some kind of sordid affair, than a marriage.

Brooke says she's going to quit in two years' time. She's saved about \$35,000 in just five months, and I've seen the statements. They confirm her savings. There's no reason not to take her plan seriously.

In fact, there's no reason not to take Brooke seriously. She's been sober and a straight-shooter for quite a while now.

It's just that her having this job is an incubator for my paranoia. All the high-class, wealthy people, all the time away from home at expensive resorts. All the rumors out there about flight attendants, the accepted myth that they sleep around. Especially if they're attractive. Especially if they work on corporate flights.

You can understand that these things aren't any more true than, say, thirty-year old women having lingerie-clad pillow fights when they stay over at each others' houses. Understanding, and truly believing, however, are two very different things.

3: CAYMAN ISLANDS

It's the next week, and Brooke's in the Cayman Islands.

I get a call from her on my cell around 7pm. I'm still at work, and I'm on hold with opposing counsel for a nasty domestic case, while he tries to fax me a new agreement he cooked up. I also sense he's just into billing a lot of hours, so I brace the phone against my shoulder and answer the call.

Brooke's pretty face fills the screen. There's a lot of noise coming from somewhere behind her, but between the elevator music being piped through my land line and the fact that my speaker phone feature crackles ever since I spilled a beer on my phone, I have no idea whether or not it's music, or people, or both.

"Hey baby," Brooke says, and she seems to be shouting to be heard. She also raises her pitch at the end of her sentence, which is more like a twenty-year old than Brooke typically behaves.

She's obviously pretty drunk.

"Hey," I say, and I can see that she's straining to hear me.

"Hold it!" she shouts. Her face suddenly blurs away and the screen goes dark.

"Brooke," I start to say. Now I can hear the background noise: it's the clatter of drunken people talking and laughing.

"Hold on just a sec," I hear Brooke say. "Huh?"

A low voice rumbles close to the phone. I pull my phone away from my ear to get a better listen, but I'm too late. The voice is undoubtedly male, and this sends the familiar nettles of jealousy prickling along my spine.

"I'll catch up," Brooke says, the screen still a half-covered blur, as though she's set it face-down on her lap or something.

Then her face is back in front of the camera.

She's flushed, though it's unclear what from. It could be the sun, or some exercise. It could also be from a wild romp with the owner of the deep voice I just heard.

My stomach tightens into a ball.

"You look... energetic," I say.

Brook's plugged her headphones into her phone and has one in her right ear. It's the wrong side and the cord crosses in front of her face, but she doesn't seem bothered by it. This is another indication that she's pretty lit: normally this sort of thing would drive her berserk. For all of her party-girl ways, Brooke's a little OCD about having things in order. She's the type to constantly straighten papers and pencils on a desk, get in a huff about something not being at right angles.

It's one of the many, many beautifully contradictory aspects of her personality that make her so attractive.

"Hey.... *yeah*," she says, in vague answer to my observation about her energy. I notice now that her eyes seem very dark, and I lean in to get a better look, but the resolution makes it hard to tell if it's her, or just the poor image quality. "*You* look like you're having a blast," she says, smiling.

"Yeah, I'm still at work... I'm on hold, actually. So, can I call you back in about... I don't know, maybe two hours?"

I'm studying her face as she listens to me. Studying the bright pink that's crawled over her cheekbones. The glossy red stain on her lips. Again, her eyes, looking almost consumed by her pupils. She doesn't answer me.

"Brooke," I say, as she smiles at someone who is evidently standing behind the phone. She's clearly started listening to that person instead of to me. "Are you *drunk*?"

Brooke's eyes snap back to the camera, though they are a little higher up. She's looking at herself, admiring her own face. "Sorry. I... Oh. I can't in two hours," she says. "That's actually why I called you, I wanted to catch you before we leave."

In my right ear, Troy Penny's voice crackles through the phone I've completely forgotten I'm holding for him.

Brooke's voice saying "we" is reverberating in my mind.

"*We*," *who*?

"Hey, Colt. You got that fax?" Penny is saying in my ear.

I set the phone down face-up on the table and hold a finger over the screen to let Brooke know I need her to wait. I hear her silvery laughter but nothing else. I swivel around and look at the fax machine next to my desk. Empty.

"Yeah, no, there's nothing here," I say. I sound exasperated. I want to talk about this fax about as much as I want to talk about dust. In the

meantime, my wife is in the Cayman Islands with multi-millionaires and a very excited flush on her cheeks. “Where’d you send it?”

A peal of laughter from my mobile. Troy sighs in my ear. We exchange fax numbers, and he puts me on hold again.

I pick up my phone. “Sorry about that,” I say.

But the call has ended.

I stare at the screen.

A lilting twitter announces a text.

[Brooke]: *Hey sweetie I had to go.*

[Brooke]: *It looks like we might be staying a couple of extra nights. That’s what I called to tell you.*

[Brooke]: *I love you. Sleep tight.*

My cheeks get hot as I read her texts.

That’s all well and fine, but it doesn’t explain why she looked drunk or high, or why there were so many people around her, or why she seemed to be having such a great time?

And why can’t she talk while she “goes” wherever she’s going?

And extra nights. Specifically, nights.

Telling.

An idea – one I’ve been having a lot lately – pops into my mind. The idea that Brooke isn’t even a flight attendant. The idea that she’s actually just... I don’t know... a groupie or some rich guy’s mistress. Maybe she isn’t even in the Cayman Islands at all. Maybe she just fuckers off and -

“Got it now?” Troy barks in my ear, bringing me in for a hard landing in reality.

The fax machine is slowly spitting out pieces of paper.

“Yeah, okay,” I snap. My voice makes me sound annoyed. It’s not at Troy, of course, but he has every reason to think it is.

He snaps back. “Great. Can you get a reply to me by tomorrow?”

Sure can do, buddy. I have no life. I have no wife at home, these days. Saturday, smatterday.

He’s hung up before I get a chance to say “Sure thing.”

I hang up the phone and stare at the wall.

I don’t want to be a paranoid prick. I’ve been fighting the urge and talking myself out of it ever since Brooke got this job.

But she's making it hard.

I pick up my phone and type a message to her. I do my best to make sure that it walks the line between not caring and being obsessive. Just a regular old husband, asking a regular old question to his wife, who is doing something he is not in any way concerned about.

[Me]: *hmm. Where are you going?*

And then, telling myself I am totally in control of my emotions, I turn my attention to the fax.

The quality is shitty and it's pretty hard to read. (Penny's one of these guys who's about fifty-seven and doesn't believe in email, still uses a fucking legal pad to take notes on.)

I'd rather pull out one of my own fingernails than call him back though, so I place the papers on my desk and squint to read them.

But I'm not reading anything. I'm thinking about my wife.

I look at my phone. The screen hasn't changed a bit.

It doesn't change. Not for the hour I spend dealing with Troy Penny's shitty proposal. Not for the half-hour I spend trying to get my client on the phone. Not for the hour I spend typing up my response, because I know my client will just agree with whatever I do.

Not until I'm home, unwrapping the plastic off a Lean Cuisine (the only thing I could find in the freezer).

[Brooke]: *sorry just got this. Going out on the town, got a free night out of the deal*

and then, a few minutes later:

[Brooke]: *with some hot guys. I'll tell u all about it later*

And then, about twenty minutes later, she sends me a picture.

I stare at it.

It's just her face. Smiling her little close-lipped, mysterious smile.

Her cheeks are close to a good-looking, dark-skinned man, who is smiling smugly.

They look cozy.

Like two party-goers on Spring Break who are about to hook up.
My gut twists, going hot and then cold. When she does this sort of thing to me, I feel like I've swallowed a lead weight and its sinking through me by liquifying all my organs.

At the same time, I get hard as a rock.
My screen lights up a moment later.

[Brooke]: *JK of course. that's just some guy at the gay club we went to ;)*

[Brooke]: *I love you xoxoxoxo. This place is actually pretty lame and I might go home early*

It's this sort of thing. Brooke driving me wild like this. Teasing me with pictures and texts and then seemingly making a joke out of it all.

I love it. I hate it. I kind of want her to stop, and I kind of want her to do more of it. Part of me wishes she didn't tell me it was a joke.

Part of me even wishes it *wasn't* a joke.

I burn my hand ripping the plastic off the heated Lean Cuisine. In my distraction I didn't peel a corner back before I stuck it in the microwave. The pain is pretty severe, so I stand with my wrist under the sink.

Do I wish that this wasn't all a joke?

Of course not. Of course I only like this feeling because I know it's not real.

Yet the best moments of it are when I think it might be.

I turn off the water, stir the meal around in the tray, and frown at it when I realize it's still frozen in the middle.

I toss it, grab a beer, fish out a box of stale crackers from the cupboard, and go to the living room, where my intentions are to watch TV and get my mind off Brooke and my paranoia.

This doesn't work of course; while I stare at the fantastical images of *Game of Thrones* playing across the screen, my mind is not on what I'm seeing at all.

I let my mind fantasize: I picture Brooke at a club that is anything but gay (I take my phone out and look at the picture again. Does this guy really seem gay? I wonder). "Take a picture with me," I imagine her saying. "I want to send it to my husband."

I wonder what the hell is wrong with me when I think about these things. I enjoy the thought of it, the burn of it right through the center of my body. Not so much just the idea of Brooke with some other man sexually; that isn't even what I spend most of my time thinking about. The perverse thing I keep going back to is the thought of her doing it all for real, then playing this game with me to cover it up.

I end up jerking off, thinking about Brooke laughing with her "gay" friend, dropping her phone onto the bed in her hotel room, and slinging her arms around his muscular shoulders while he moves in to devour her mouth.

Then I fall asleep on the couch, feeling bad.

*

The next evening, I get a flutter in my heart when I turn the corner and see that the lights are on in the house.

Brooke is home.

It's strange that she hasn't sent me a text to tell when she's arriving, or that she has enough time between flights to come home and settle in. Also, I thought she would be gone longer.

I find it unsettling that she hasn't communicated with me, but I chalk it up to the creeping paranoia I am trying to pretend I don't suffer from. I tuck it away and put on a smile as I open the door.

The other reason she lets know when she'll be home is so I can catch her still in her uniform. It's kind of our thing, playing this game right when she gets home and she's still dressed up like a flight attendant.

I'm surprised to find her in the kitchen, flipping through a magazine, in a pair of sweats. While they're tight-fitting, and essentially everything is sexy on Brooke, it's still a bit of a disappointment.

She looks up at me when I come in. "Oh, hi," she says.

I watch her as she closes her magazine and looks at me attentively.

Good, I think. That's good.

But she doesn't cross the room to hug me, which is bad.

I'm annoying myself with my constant mental accounting of Brooke's affections, but I just can't stop.

"How come you didn't send me a text or anything?" I say, setting my briefcase down in a chair.

Brooke looks genuinely confused. “Huh? I did, like... I don’t know, three hours ago.”

I take out my phone.

There’s nothing there. Brooke has re-opened her magazine, and she doesn’t seem to care if I find the messages or not.

I open my mouth to tell her there’s no message, but I decide better. It isn’t as if it matters, and it isn’t as if messages have never been lost before, or arrived late because of the mysteries of international networks.

There is a silence that I decide is longer-than-normal.

“So...” I say. “How was your trip?”

At almost exactly the same time, Brooke says: “Are you hungry? What do you want for dinner?”

“Oh,” she says. She gives me a smile. “It was okay. It rained. And then the beach was a little gross. So not as exciting as I’d hoped for.”

“Huh,” I say. “That’s too bad.”

I add: “I thought you said you got an extra day or something?”

Brooke barely registers this question. “Yeah, I did...what? Oh. Yeah, he changed his mind because of the weather. Did you see these goofy dog beds that look like tree houses?”

She holds the magazine up so I can see.

“Funny,” I say.

There’s a long pause while Brooke grins at the doghouses.

“Dinner,” I say, remembering that she’s asked. “Um... sure, I’m hungry.”

I’m trying to hide my disappointment. I want to ignite whatever it is that makes her start talking about things that *didn’t* happen on her trip. I’ll admit it, I’m a dirty guy, and I enjoy our game.

But I don’t want to seem lecherous.

Before we started playing this “game,” our marriage, like any other I suppose, had hit a little bit of a stale point. We had been married for seven years, and more often than not, we had clockwork evenings: decide what to eat, have sex if we had some wine. Brooke had a steady schedule, she was out of town for set amounts of time on set days, and that’s how it went.

But the game we had started playing had changed all that. We had gotten pretty drunk one night (Brooke had been quite a partier when I’d met her, and while she’d toned it down and could no longer do anything but drink and only on days when she was nowhere near getting on a plane) and

I'd started probing her about her trip. Somehow, she'd figured out that I wanted to hear about her being naughty, and I'd sort of led her to say what I wanted her to say.

It had made a big improvement in our love life. And it seemed to work for both of us. Things had stopped being dull and begun getting wilder with every passing day. No more straight-up missionary sex on Thursday and Sunday nights. Sex in the car, blowjobs in the bathroom. Wild stories of Brooke fucking men in the lavatory on the plane, giving handjobs in first class, and hooking up with men during layovers.

It had all steamrolled up to this point, and like an addiction, I was always craving more.

It is therefore all but impossible not to find the fact that she isn't throwing herself at me right now to be anything but some kind of rebuke. I know it isn't fair or reasonable, it's just the way I feel.

"Can we do pizza?" Brooke says, turning to the freezer for a frozen one. "I don't feel like cooking."

This kind of normal, everyday conversation shouldn't bother me as much as it does, but it's getting under my skin. Why? Why is she suddenly wearing sweats and making a frozen pizza?

I loosen my tie and go toward the fridge, partly to get a beer and partly to be closer to her.

Surely Brooke, who is no one's fool, knows that she's behaving differently than usual.

I give her a feathery brush of my fingers at the nape of her neck as I open the fridge. She tips her head to the side and grins, and I'm certain I can feel her skin ripple with goosebumps.

"So... did you meet anyone interesting on your trip?" I prompt.

There couldn't possibly be a more obvious clue than this one.

Brooke crouches down to fish an unwieldy pizza stone out of the cupboard. She looks up at me, as if she has no idea where such a question is headed.

She makes a face. "Not really," she says. "It was a pretty dull trip all around."

I help her with the pizza stone as she rises to standing. I feel rebuked, and I'm annoyed with myself for that.

After all, sometimes a trip to the Cayman Islands can be a drag. Sure thing.

The thing of it is, Brooke *always* manages to tell a good story when she comes home.

They're all fake anyway, right? So why does it matter if this trip was actually boring?

She tosses the pizza on the pizza stone and takes it over to the counter next to the oven.

"You looked like you were having a good time at that party," I suggest.

She turns back to me. "It *was* pretty fun..."

My blood boils.

"...but it was all gay guys."

She opens the oven and peers inside. "The client was gay," she says offhand.

Okay. There we go. A gay client. No shenanigans. Makes sense.

That's all there is to this.

There's just no story to tell.

I can't help myself. I head toward her and slide my hands around her hips. "Oh," I say. "That's too bad. So I guess there were no adventures on your trip."

Brooke turns and smiles at me. She pecks me on the mouth and then squirms away from me. "Well..." she says. "I didn't say that."

There's a vague hint of sexual innuendo to her voice, but it seems like she's trying more than she's actually interested.

The her face falls a little. She sighs.

"You know? I just... I need to eat first. Maybe watch some TV. I'm sorry. These guys were really demanding. Like, *really demanding*. I'm sort of in a chill out on the couch mood."

"Netflix and chill?" I say hopefully.

Brooke laughs. "We'll see." She opens the fridge and gets out two beers. Then she heads for the living room. "That's gonna take like twenty minutes," she says. "Let's get an episode of something really dumb in while we wait."

We end up having a nice night.

I think. Brooke is really into her TV, and her pizza, and she seems spaced out. She has a lot more beer than usual (four) and digs into the cupboard for a glass of wine.

This only fuels my theories of her having done something with another man. Now she has to get drunk to be around me. I see.

All night long I think about how her behavior could be interpreted in one of many ways: maybe she really is just tired from demanding gay clients. I have no right to expect that she's going to come home and throw herself at me, dirty-talking, after every single trip. And if these guys really were gay and annoying, then she probably is just tired.

It isn't like she's totally ignoring me. She's laughing at all the right parts in the TV shows; her thoughts aren't miles away on some rich lover.

But the paranoid inside of me can't help thinking of darker ideas and explanations. Maybe Brooke *is* thinking of another man, a more satisfying man, and just has no interest in sex because she's been laid so well on her trip she can barely walk. Maybe her hunk of a lover had such a huge cock that she feels like it would be a waste of time to have me sloshing around inside of her. Maybe she's just too sore to even consider it.

She smiles at me every now and then, when something is funny and she wants me to share in it. Or maybe because she senses that I'm staring at her and she wants me to stop.

"Well," she says, at around nine-thirty. "I'm done. I'm going to sleep in tomorrow and then..." she stretches and yawns. "You want to go out for breakfast at that one place with the corned beef thing?"

She's pretty tipsy – that was a lot of booze in a short time for a small person, and Brooke hardly ever drinks because she's always on call. It's strange, in fact, that she has. Just one more strange thing about her behavior.

"Uh, sure," I say.

She goes to the bedroom without waiting for me, and again, I don't know if it's because she's drunk, or she just doesn't want me to come. I wait for a bit, then follow her. She's already in bed when I get there.

I climb in next to her and prop myself up behind her. I expect her to pretend to be asleep, but she smiles when I touch her arm.

I take it for encouragement, like any guy would. I slip my hand down the front of her body and find her lower body bare. My fingers slip into her pussy, cup her soft flesh. I explore her folds, fingering how wet they are – not very – and whether there is something discernibly different about her body.

She lies still for a while, but eventually comes around, squirming against me, and then rolling toward me.

We have sex that's much more like the sex we had before we started this game. Brooke doesn't offer any stories or dirty talk, and since she usually instigates it, I don't have any idea what to say to prompt her to do it.

But her silence is almost as delicious as any game we've ever played, at least in my demented imagination. I'm just as turned on as I fuck her, and she seems only mildly interested. In my mind, I imagine that she's only partially present... her thoughts are really on another man.

She's asleep by ten. I'm awake, restless, late into the night, my mind plagued by scenario after scenario in which my wife has finally cheated on me for real.

4: CYPRUS

The next morning, Brooke is up early and buzzing around in her closet.

I sit up and wipe the sleep from my eyes. I have a little bit of a hangover. Brooke, just judging by the way she's swinging her hangers and clothes around, does not.

"I thought you were going to sleep in," I said, drowsily. "And we were going out for breakfast."

I'm already getting a bad feeling as I'm watching her. She's folding her clothes into neat little squares with a practiced flip.

She's packing.

"I got a text around 2am," she says. "It's a sub job, so last-minute. But I can't turn it down." She turns to me and grins. "It's to *Cyprus*. A whole week. And I get paid extra for taking it last-minute."

She swings a shirt up to create a tidy rectangle and creases it against her chest. She has an almost erotic way of folding clothes: ruthless, perfectionist, and efficient.

I rub my eye.

I don't like it, I want to tell her.

Cyprus, for one thing. Russian mafia is pretty much the only thing that comes to mind. That alone makes my stomach queasy.

A week? That's another. Because that's a whole week she'll be gone. And only working like 16 hours of the time.

"What are you going to do in Cyprus for a week?" I say, incredulously.

Brooke shrugs. "Roll around in my money? Read a book?"

Then she gets a little grin. "Find a hot pool boy to amuse me."

I want to tell her that's enough. That all of this is enough. I'm tired of the game, I'm getting worried it's going too far. I want to have the balls to ask her to call the trip off, or at the very least to make some kind of promise to me that she'll lock herself up in her room and actually read a book the whole time.

This is what Brooke says she does, by the way, when I press her on it. After the games, after telling me that she fucked all these men in the

filthiest ways possible, she tells me what she actually did. Usually, she claims to sit around reading books.

And I have no reason to doubt this. She talks about them. She talks about them like a person who has actually read them.

Brooke has turned around and is piling her tidy little triangles of clothing up, getting ready to place them into her “long-trip” bag. She likes that at her new job, she doesn’t have to conserve so much space on longer trips.

“Who’s your client?” I say grumpily. “You know a lot of those Cyprus trips are for Russian mafia.”

Brooke turns around, walking briskly out of the closet. “Not my concern what they do or how they do it,” she says. “What *is* my concern is that I get a whole week of sun and a \$10,000 bonus.”

“You’re shitting me.”

She shakes her head. “I’m not. So...” she flaps a hand at me to scoot over so she can set her suitcase on the bed. “Scoot, I have to hurry.”

She dumps a bunch of things into the open suitcase in a hurried way, and this gets my attention because, after all that careful folding, it’s a little cavalier. Very unlike her. She places the items in the suitcase in this strange way, and rushes toward the vanity.

My curiosity is piqued, but in slow motion. It takes a little time for the idea to work its way through my mind. Before I even have a conscious thought about it, I’m reaching toward the suitcase, into the clothes. Because the way she was placing things in there, I realize, was like she was trying to hide something from me. As if there were something in the pile that it was very important to get tucked away...

Brooke turns as she’s halfway to the vanity, and stops abruptly. I see that she doesn’t want me doing what I’m doing, and perhaps even a look of worry crosses her face. “Hey!” she says.

But it’s too late. My fingers have already pulled things apart, opening up the folds of silky shirts and swimsuits and dresses to reveal:

Lingerie.

It’s unmistakable that that’s what it is, even before I give it a tug and the whole sordid shape of it comes sliding out. Maybe it could be a bra, or panties, I think at first. The material is thin, grayish black, and transparent, with a trim of shiny embroidery.

Brooke wears nice things, so before I see the whole thing, there's still a chance that everything that has happened up to this moment has another explanation.

But when the scrap of fabric – because it's little more than that, a scrap – is held aloft in my hand, and I see it there, swinging in the air, there's little left to question.

“What's this?” I say. I mean for it to come out teasing, but it sounds hoarse, accusatory and hurt at the same time. Flat, and emotional. It's barely recognizable as a human voice.

Because I know what it is: it's the kind of ultra-sexy lingerie that you only put on because you want someone else to take it off. It's a one-piece, impractical, highly revealing, slutty slip of fabric with no other possible purpose but to titillate a man right before he rips it off.

And it's in her suitcase, for a week-long trip to Cyprus.

I turn to Brooke, who's face is reconstituting itself into an expression of emergency-level calm. She's about to calmly direct me to an emergency exit or ask me to tug on my oxygen mask to get the air flowing.

She even smiles.

“Pretty sexy, isn't it?”

I give her a look. I wouldn't know what to call the look, because I'm not sure what I'm feeling. But basically, it's meant to say: I'm not buying your shit.

“What's it doing in your luggage.”

I say this, not ask. I lob it at her more like a rock than a question.

Brooke's lip quivers for a nanosecond. She does not have an answer to this question immediately, and the tightly plastered emergency-calm smile cracks. For a second it looks like the whole facade of her face is going to slide off, like the side of a building after an earthquake.

But the moment is gone. Brooke shrugs and turns back to the vanity. “Beats me,” she says. “Must have gotten stuck to something in the laundry.”

This is good, I think. A good, plausible explanation.

Brooke takes two steps toward the vanity and pulls a drawer out. She looks down at it and her lip quivers a little.

Like a lightning storm, my brain fires up with everything that is wrong about that statement, though. Brooke doesn't wash her bras or panties in with everything else, and she hardly puts anything in the dryer, and most of her clothes can't even be washed, they have to be dry-cleaned.

“Brooke,” I say, and my stomach is cold. I’ve still got this lingerie suspended in the air, an accusation, a lacy wisp of an elephant in the room.

Brooke’s face does crumble at that moment. Her mouth turns down, and into a frown.

My stomach turns to ice, and so does all the blood in my veins. This is it, I think. My wife is going to tell me that all the paranoid delusions I’ve suffered this past year are really just how it is.

Brooke meets my eyes in the mirror. She composes her face.

And then we look at each other. She’s not going to finish my sentence for me, her eyes say.

This staring contest goes on for a moment, and then Brooke raises her eyebrows. “What?” she says, and shrugs again. She leans toward the mirror, a tube of lipstick materializing in her hand, and she begins to smear a pretty shade of red on her mouth. “It’s too bad,” she says calmly. “It was supposed to be a surprise.”

My heart changes suddenly. Brooke seems overly calm, as though she really doesn’t care about this lingerie.

I feel foolish all at once. I drop the lingerie.

What if it really was just a piece of errant laundry? What if it had been purchased as a surprise for me? What if I was just losing my mind and being paranoid?

“I got it in this shop in the Caymans,” Brooke is saying cheerfully, her eyes wide as she applies mascara. “You would not believe some of the stuff they have in there. You think that’s tiny, you should have seen this other one...”

Her voice trails off, and she presses her lips together. She looks at herself in the mirror.

I am almost 100% certain I see the crack in her facade again. A shiftiness in her eyes, a turn downward of her mouth. A fleeting expression of disappointment, or panic, or something that rarely takes shape on Brooke’s face.

It is gone almost as quickly as it appeared, leaving me to wonder if it was ever there at all.

Efficient, flight-attendant Brooke is back at the side of the bed, hair coiffed, make-up flawless, snapping her suitcase items into the container in brisk, efficient strokes. She doesn’t look at me as she organizes.

She leaves the lingerie in my hand.

She leans over the suitcase before locking it and moves her lips in front of mine, her form of kissing once she has her makeup on. “I love you,” she says. “I’ll call you from the airport if I have some extra time. Just depends on rush hour.”

And just like that, she is gone. I’m left holding a scrap of sexy fabric, my heart slamming into my chest, wondering if my wife is cheating on me or I am a total nut job.

*

I typically find it idiotic when people turn to the internet for advice. I find it most annoying from my clients, who come in spouting all sorts of crazy shit after a spin on the internet, many of whom do not seem to believe me at all when I tell them laws vary from one state to another and so this case law they’re yapping about from Louisiana isn’t going to change jack-all.

Still, here I am.

On the internet, looking for the answers to personal questions.

I don’t know what I’m hoping to find when I type in: *how to tell if your wife is cheating on you*.

Do I want confirmation that she is, or that she isn’t?

Do I hope to find that my wife has all the same symptoms of an outrageous slut?

I read a few articles. They’re all pretty useless, perhaps because I don’t know what I’m looking for. I also start to doubt myself and what I observed with Brooke.

Was she actually less interested in our game?

Or was I just being paranoid?

Did her explanation for the lingerie make sense?

Or was I just being paranoid?

I type: *Am I being paranoid?* into Google.

Surprisingly (or perhaps not) most of the links generated by this broad and unspecified question return exactly the answers I am looking for: ie, am I being paranoid about my wife cheating on me?

I’m not sure if I’m relieved that I’m just a normal person, or annoyed that there is nothing special about this kind of thinking.

All that reading these pages really does for me, though, is give me ideas.

You might be paranoid, “The Internet” says, if you are checking her emails.

If you start to wonder about her exes.

If you are thinking about her with other men all the time.

Check, check, check.

I set the tablet down after I spend about two hours – until three in the morning – drifting around the internet. I find all kinds of things out there. Tests for her underwear. Surveillance equipment. Tips on how to place tracking devices on her phone. Endless lists of behaviors of cheating wives. Seven ways to know she’s thinking of another. Ten signs your wife is having sex with someone else.

I lie face-up on the bed and stare at the ceiling before I close my eyes.

I know already I’m not going to get any sleep, and this is bad because I have a lot of shit to do tomorrow. My whole body is rigid, and I’m gritting my teeth. I should get up and work, but I don’t. I lay there, turning over all of these things in my mind, imagining scene after scene of me confronting Brooke. In some of them she starts crying and tells me she cheated on me. In others she laughs and gives her hair a little toss, before she cruelly recounts all her hundreds of lovers and how much better they were than I am.

It’s five by the time I give up on sleep.

I hold my phone over my head, hopeful that somehow I’ve missed the vibration of the phone, and Brooke has sent me a message, a reply, a missed call.

But there is nothing.

I get up and take a shower and head for the gym I’ve had a membership with for the past six months and used only twice.

*

It’s a whole day and night before I hear from Brooke. A text message arrives in the middle of the night, and somehow doesn’t wake me. I stare at it in the morning, at the strange time stamp that reads 8:05pm, even though I know I checked my phone a hundred times last night.

[Brooke]: *it turns out its not Cyprus, were on some other island. No service. Im on a boat I just got signal – sending this quick. also texts r like \$45 ea lol Love u dont worry c u Wed*

My eyes pass over the words again and again.

It reads like a telegraph.

It's also, like so many things that Brooke has done lately, plausible only at first glance. Within moments it seems less likely, less possible, not even sensible.

No *signal*? If by this she is trying to say that there is no internet where she is I don't buy it for a second. Don't these billionaire-types have to send data all the time to manage their financial empire?

Brooke is also an ultra-worldly person (naturally) when it comes to managing her cellphone abroad. She could find a local SIM card under a rock in the Sahara if she needed one, and so the claim that texts were going to be hyper-expensive doesn't hold any water, either.

In fact, the more I stare at it, the more the text seems like a really, really smoking gun. It's such an obvious, poorly-written, poorly-thought out excuse for not being in touch with me.

I squeeze the phone with a sense of triumph. At last, the confirmation I... was looking for?

But almost immediately, I start to doubt my own logic.

If Brooke were actually having an affair, wouldn't she be smarter about it?

A wave of relief washes over me.

This is probably all part of her game.

This is just one big, long, elaborate tease. She's figured out what a total psycho I am and how much it presses my buttons to think – seriously think – she's having an affair, and she's toying with me.

I go up and down a few times, from the apex of excitement to the nadir of despair again.

*

It's a long, long week. With no communication from Brooke, my thoughts take a turn from paranoid to completely insane.

By the time Wednesday, her anticipated return date, rolls around, I have entertained ideas that Brooke is not even a flight attendant, that she isn't in Cyprus at all, but at some corporate executive's house, having a run-of-the-mill affair. I've considered that everything she's told me is true; and all the guys she's fucked in her "stories" have piled up in my mind, a montage of athletes and corporate executives who have had their dicks in Brooke's mouth.

I watch porn, I research cheating wives. I wonder about the expense of getting a private investigator, I create fantasies of flying to the places she's going to, to spy on her.

It gets really wild. I can't tell if I'm enjoying myself or not. I feel sick and I'm constantly getting turned on.

Once again, the day of her return rolls around and I get no texts from her all day.

My paranoia turns into a little bit of anger.

I'm pretty sure Brooke doesn't think this much about me, and what I'm doing. Doesn't suffer from constant thoughts about fucking me, or who I'm fucking, or the guilt of enjoying thinking about me fucking someone else. I'm sure Brooke doesn't have any idea how my stomach feels like a block of ice, or my heart feels like it's being squeezed in a vice.

I'm actually grateful that I've had a lot of tough cases this week. I even managed to take my mind off my wife for half a day. I look in my rear-view mirror when I pull into the driveway at home. I look pretty good for a man who is having as crazy of a train of thoughts as I am. Brooke isn't back yet, and I pull out my phone one more time to check for messages.

Nothing.

I go inside. I re-read her messages to check that she is, in fact, planning to return today. She forwarded me an itinerary last week, I guess when she was waiting at the airport, just like she always does. I never pay them any mind, though, because they almost always change.

I weigh the pros and cons of making a nice dinner and then having her not show up.

I decide to do some work and try to be nonchalant.

I work for about an hour, and when I come into the kitchen, I hear her car in the driveway.

I freeze.

It's a strange feeling, feeling this way about your spouse. Wanting to see her, being nervous about seeing her. Wanting to catch her at something and wanting to not.

I stand at the counter, a coffee mug of beer in my hand.

"Oh, hi," Brooke says, pushing a loose lock of hair out of her face. She seems surprised to see me.

Or maybe disappointed.

I know that I'm paranoid, and I know that I'm prone to delusional thoughts, possible more because I like them than because I don't. But something is definitely up with the way Brooke is acting.

Something is off.

She doesn't look me in the eye. She drops her gaze to her suitcase, which she is now tugging awkwardly through the door as if she's never traveled with luggage before. The suitcase has caught on the door frame, she pulls at it and it gives, sending her and it clattering into the kitchen like she's some kind of rookie.

"Oh, hi?" I say. I cross the room and reach out for her. She puts a cheek toward my mouth in what is more of a slap to my face than an invitation to kiss her cheek. I kiss it anyway, even though this is the kind of overly-formal gesture we have never done in all our years of marriage.

It feels like an ice pick through my gut.

But I still don't have the balls to do anything about it. "How was Cyprus?" I say.

Brooke tips her luggage and gives it a little kick backward to turn it around. "Oh, you know."

I don't know. I don't have any idea what the hell Cyprus is like.

"I'm really... I have that airplane-air feeling," she says. "I'm just gonna... take a shower."

She leaves her suitcase leaning against the counter, walks into the hallway, and doesn't give me another look.

It seems to me that she's in a real hurry.

I follow her. Not right behind her. I wait until she might not hear me behind her in the plush carpet.

I watch her from behind like I'm looking at another person in my house. There seems to be some great divide between us all of a sudden. Brooke seems like someone else's wife.

Distracted.

Thinking of someone else.

She has the characteristics of every description I read the other day on the internet about cheating wives.

Taking a shower right away, to boot.

My stomach twists. Also, this thing about the “Airplane-air” smell.

That was long-gone. That was a commercial-airline thing, a thing that didn’t happen to the air in the plush, leather-seated airplanes she flies on now. Where gourmet chefs prepare real food and not microwaved crap.

I hang back, my stomach in knots, debating my options.

I feel like the facts are all there. Almost incontrovertible. It’s obvious that my wife is having an affair, or cheating on me, or something, and I’m a fool not to confront her.

I watch Brooke moving in the room. I can only see a part of her body; the rest is shadows. She slips a stocking from her leg (at this gig, thigh-high stockings are allowed – and no wonder, I grumble to myself, if she’s going to be boinking every Tom, Dick and High-Rolling Harry) and tosses it on the bed. I don’t see her peeling the other one away, just her form, bending to take it off, the skirt hiked up to her ass.

Her fingers unzip the black skirt, and it slides over her hips and crumples on the floor.

My mind reels as I stare at the scene:

Her ass is bare.

She has no underwear on.

I am gripped by a force in my head that makes me feel like my brain might explode. I am all but running down the hall when I see her hook her finger under something.

A thong. A beige thong, almost the color of her skin.

She steps out of her underwear and turns at the same time. She sees me, reacts with mild surprise, and then turns around fully. My eyes go straight to her bare snatch, although more for reasons of inspecting it than anything else.

Though she doesn’t know this, thank god.

She unhooks her bra, and for a moment I think she’s going to be seductive and do a strip-tease.

Then I look at her face. Her eyelids are heavy. For the first time I notice that she has some kind of dark makeup on her lids.

Are her eyes heavy, or does she look sultry because of her makeup?

I am now at the doorway of the bedroom. Brooke is looking tired, and she turns to go to the bathroom. "Honey, I'm so tired," she says. "That was a really long flight... everything went wrong... I just want a shower and to go to bed," she says. "Sorry."

She steps into the shower, and suddenly I feel like an ass. She's jet-lagged, she just worked a nine-hour shift plus all of the prep and travel to the airport and back. I usually catch her when she's had a shorter flight, or a nap, or she's on her way somewhere.

Still, it burns a little the way she's said it to me. Like she's exasperated that I've just come down here for sex.

I'm re-thinking all of my conclusions, feeling less sure of them.

I reach down and pick up her underwear. I rub it between my thumb and forefinger. It's damp: not inexplicably or conclusively so, just damp. The idea of sending it in to be analyzed flits through my head, but I feel suddenly foolish and drop it back on the floor.

I pick up her clothes and bring them to my nose, as if I have a superhuman sense of smell and will be able to detect something, confirm or deny the things I'm thinking. The shower water is running, and I breathe in nothing but the scent of her soap and the smell of her skin.

"Do you want dinner?" I call out.

There's a pause. "Yeah... no, I don't think so. I'm really just beat. I need some sleep." She pauses before adding: "Jetlag."

"Okay," I say.

Then, unsure what to do, whether I should wait around for her to get out and say goodnight, or wait for her to come to me, I stand there some more. I suddenly feel creepy, so I get up and return to the kitchen.

Her suitcase is right there, with her purse fitted neatly atop it. I eye it while I grab my coffee mug and, because we're out of beer, pour myself some wine in it.

It's too far, I think. Searching through her stuff is going too far.

I drink the wine, twisting with the desire to open her bag, one ear straining to hear where she is or what she's doing. I wonder if I still have time to get into her stuff. I only want to do it more, and it only gets even more dangerous, with every passing second.

But then minutes tick by, and pretty soon it's too much time, even for a really long shower.

"Honey?" I say, walking down the hall.

Brooke is in bed – the light is still on and she seems to have barely made it. I stand in the doorway.

She's asleep.

I turn out the light and close the door.

Okay, I tell myself.

Add it all up.

I really, *really* want to go through her suitcase. I want to get her phone out and check her messages. I want to dig into her belongings and find.. I don't know what I want to find. Lingerie or something. I know it's wrong and breaks our trust and all of that, but I really, really want to do it.

Because what about the lingerie, from a week ago, hidden in her suitcase?

What about her being so tired?

What about her falling asleep even though it's morning in Cyprus, and the fact that she's always seemed utterly impermeable to the effects of jetlag before? What about if she just wants to avoid having sex?

"Come on, Colt," I say.

There are reasonable explanations for all of that, none of which are "your wife is cheating on you."

You're being paranoid, I tell myself.

But in the meantime I'm walking down the hall, my palms itching like they've already unzipped her bag and plunged into her personal effects.

Before I know it, I'm there. I have her suitcase open on the floor and I'm rifling through her things.

I pull out her underwear – the pairs that have been used. I feel the center of them, and on some of them I find evidence (I guess) that she was aroused when she wore them. I smell them, thinking maybe I'll find the scent of another man. But I find nothing.

Of course, that doesn't mean anything. She could have done anything in Cyprus. Bought new lingerie... thrown it out. I could picture her slinking up to her rich Russian mafia guy: *My husband found the lingerie you bought me, and I had to leave it behind. So can you get me a new one?*

Anything for you, the big fat bastard would say.

I sit back on my heels, disappointed.

I'm disappointed in myself. Disappointed in the inconclusiveness of my findings.

Then my eyes rest on the purse.

Don't.

I open it with relish and seize her phone.

But Brooke has locked it, of course.

It's a pattern lock.

I set it aside. Brooke's mind is unknowable with that. I could take to guessing later.

I find her passport and open it. It's littered with pages and pages of stamps, many of them stamped over the stamps so they were hardly legible. I remember that she was going to be flown by the company, in the upcoming weeks, to a passport office where she could get a new passport rapidly, and that she had to have extra pages for her frequent travel.

I try for a few minutes to add up the stamps and my recollections of where she had flown, but the task proves impossible. I toss the passport back in the purse and dig into her things.

But there isn't anything to find. Brooke's tidy wallet holds not one single extra scrap of paper. She has her cards neatly organized, and cash in three different compartments. One American, one full of Euros in small denominations, and one with a mix of currencies I didn't immediately recognize.

Useless.

If there is thing you could count on Brooke for, it's to be OCD about her own belongings.

This does mean, however, that if I find anything, I can be sure that it isn't there by accident.

I dig through what remains in her purse and find a pack of cigarettes, which I stare at and feel a little queasy looking at. She told me she'd stopped smoking years ago.

This is definitely her brand, not someone else's. Rothman's, some wacky English cigarette. And a lighter, a silver one, an expensive-looking one that is clearly not the purchase of a non-smoker who only just fell off the wagon.

I feel a little queasy, but I keep going. Red lipstick, a pair of socks.

That's it.

I sit down on the floor, feeling miserable.

I pick up the phone. I stare at it absent-mindedly, until I forget what I'm doing. Without even thinking about it. I move my thumb around in the pattern for my own phone.

And I'm in.

I read over the messages quickly, then slowly, then with an attention to detail that would get me a job at the FBI. As I do this, my mind seems to leave my body and observe myself.

There is an exchange with a "Micah." This goes all the way back to months ago, so I assume it must be a co-worker. A lot of the conversations from the months before are short exchanges about where planes are and negotiations to share rides.

But Micah also features prominently in texts from the past week.

SEPTEMBER 12 4:37PM [Micah]: *where are uuuuuuu? we are leaving for hot party in like 5*

SEPTEMBER 12 4:38PM [Me]: wait for me. Be right there

SEPTEMBER 13 6:38PM [Micah]: come over here

SEPTEMBER 13 6:40PM [Me]: no way

SEPTEMBER 13 7:56 PM [Micah] don't say I didn't warn you

SEPTEMBER 14 4:13PM[Micah]: he wants a friend to come

SEPTEMBER 14 4:18PM[Micah]: you're perfect

SEPTEMBER 14 4:19PM[Me]: not my bag

SEPTEMBER 14 5:06PM[Micah]: pleeeeeease! all you have to do is watch

SEPTEMBER 14 5:08PM[Me]: get bent you crazy beatch

SEPTEMBER 14 5:37PM[Micah]: come on, just come over for one drink i'll introduce you

SEPTEMBER 15 6:31PM[Me]: going home

SEPTEMBER 15 7:12PM[Micah]: come over

I read and re-read.

On the one hand, it seems that Micah is wilder than my wife. That she was invited to something risqué and resisted.

But looking at the times, and the stamps, and the missing pieces in the conversation, I start to doubt my conclusions.

"All you have to do is watch?"

It hardly seems like there's any way to interpret that as an innocuous, non-sexual invitation. What else could someone watch?

And did my wife "come over" in the end? There are no more texts between her and Micah. Did Micah introduce her to the person she wanted her to meet? Did my wife actually go home, as she said she would? The texts say nothing.

The only thing the texts do confirm is what I have suspected all along: there are some less-than-professional propositions being made on these trips.

But whether my wife partakes of them is still inconclusive.

I wade through her other messages and fail to find anything juicy or incriminating.

At first, this lack of findings is a consolation. But it doesn't take me long to spin it up into the worse of all possible scenarios. Of course, there wouldn't be anything there. She would delete anything truly incriminating.

And there would be no messages between her and someone she fucked on the plane, anyway.

I keep going.

I sift through her email. It's largely a bust; a series of emails and messages about her schedule. Calls to come in and work. Nothing unseemly, no matter how far I dig through her messages.

None of her messages even seem particularly personal. This gets me to wondering about my wife. Who does she confide in? Who does she tell all of her deep, girly secrets to? It isn't me, these days. We don't have time, we're never in the same place.

I have a sudden attack of sadness. It's as if for the first time, I realize that we have been growing apart. We hardly spend any time together. I've been telling myself it's all temporary, because that's how she's framed it.

But is it temporary? Or is it a move away from each other, down the road toward the slow decay of our marriage? Why are we doing this? Why is she doing this? Is it really just the money, and is she really going to give it up in a short while?

I spend almost three hours digging through her impersonal, professional emails. I re-read her messages, especially those between her and Micah. I realize that the woman in these messages and emails seems like a stranger. There are no personal clues to tell me what she thinks, or what she feels.

And I myself don't know if I can answer that question, because it's been such a long time since we've had a talk that didn't center around our "game," or our work.

When I think of work, I look at the clock, bleary-eyed. I have to be at work in about eight hours. I need to go to bed.

I try to summarize what I've learned, like I'm building a case. If I can come to some conclusion about what is happening with Brooke, then maybe I can put it out of my mind and go to bed.

What am I accusing Brooke of? Cheating on me.

And what is my evidence?

The lingerie, the text messages. Something "strange" about her behavior.

All of which have other, plausible explanations than "Brooke is cheating on me."

I rub my eyes. I'm not a criminal lawyer, but any fool can see "circumstantial evidence" written all over this one.

What's more, I really have no business going through her phone. All of these conversations with Micah are inadmissible, unless I want a huge headache, which I don't. Unless I know she's cheating on me for sure, I don't want to look like an ass here.

I go to bed, dissatisfied with my conclusion, which isn't a conclusion at all. I replay every word I read in her emails, every look she has given me in the past few weeks, every word, every interaction, every long night when I couldn't get a hold of her.

I'm still awake at 4:00am. Brooke is sleeping soundly. She hardly moved all night.

I calculate: she's been sleeping since about 7:30. It's almost nine hours of sleep.

I place my hand on her arm, and move my fingers down the length of it. I have barely brought my lips to the skin of her shoulder when she shrugs me away. "Colt," she groans. "I'm just so tired. Don't."

I ponder this. Brooke's not one to brush me off, usually, but when she does, she means it.

My heart feels crushed.

I remind myself that she has done this before, and it was about sleep then, too. The simple explanation that she is tired is probably the right one.

I stare at her face, at the uncomplicated expression on her mouth. If she were guilty of something wouldn't she feel troubled? Too troubled to sleep?

I contemplate trying again, and my fingers itch to do it, but in the end I roll over onto my back. I have a morning erection that's been made worse by all of the intrusive thoughts I've had. The rejection, the lingerie, the texts.

All you have to do is watch.

I get up and go downstairs, where a dusty exercise bike sits largely unused in the corner of a half-finished workout room. There's an old computer there so we can watch Netflix while we work out. I put on a documentary about sharks, and settle uncomfortably onto the seat to do some exercise.

*

I have to be in to the office early to get things prepped for what is ostensibly two court sessions in one day. Brooke is still asleep (or, I think sourly, pretending to be asleep) all through my shower, so I kiss her on the forehead and write her a note.

It's disturbing to me – extremely so – that she's been sleeping for so long.

Is it because she was awake all week? Partying? Fucking?

I go to work and throw myself into my business for the day, hoping it will take my mind off my problems, but it eats at me through the morning, through the afternoon, well into the evening. I'm checking my phone all day like a teenager. Wanting Brooke to write to me, to tell me she's sorry she slept for so long, won't I please meet her for "lunch?" Hoping she will pop by the office and show me what she did on the plane, tucked away in a closet somewhere for a realistic effect.

But none of these things happen.

By the afternoon, I'm broiling. After a week of paranoid thinking, last night's strange behavior has pushed me over the edge.

And her text messages. The thought of them slams down on me. There's no real explaining those away.

I have to confront her, I realize. I come to that conclusion and then I try to run away from it all day. But it keeps coming back, growling at me

from every corner.

I have to do it.

I call Brooke around 5:30pm. As I dial, I'm not even sure what it is I'm going to say. But the idea that I have to confront her has been brewing all day and at some point, as with anything confrontational, I just run toward it even if I don't have a plan.

It's been such a long time since I've called her on the phone, I stumble over the greeting. She answers with a formal, "Hello?"

"Uh... Brooke?"

She laughs, and so do I.

"Sorry," I say. "I just, um... jeez, I never call you."

"Yeah," she says.

I'm not sure how to read her tone. Is she annoyed that I called? Or of the reminder that I never call?

And why am I having this kind of mental struggle surrounding a phone call to my own wife?

"Uh.. so... the reason for my call is to..." My mind draws a blank. I've made this call with no plan whatsoever. "Um, see if you are free tonight."

There is a long pause, and I actually have the terrified feeling I used to get when I was asking girls out on a date.

"Uh... you mean, like for a date or something?" she says.

"Yeah. Exactly. I... uh... was just thinking last night how we never get to see each other, you know... for dinner or anything."

My heart goes on a roller coaster as I wait for her to answer.

"Huh," she says. And there is another painful silence, that grips me like I'm holding my breath. "Well, as it so happens, I *do* have tonight free. So... yeah. Where do you want to go?"

"I was thinking a steak or something. Or something fancy like Bella Giardina."

There is another long pause.

"Would you mind doing something crazy?" she asks. "I haven't had any Chinese food in forever."

I try to picture my plan to spend time with her and seduce her, and tease the answers I want from her, taking place in a Chinese restaurant. I just got the idea, but now that I have it, I'm having a hard time changing course.

It's not what I envisioned. I'm stalled.

"It's just that I've been eating at all these hoity-toity places lately and I kind of just want some greasy, mildly crappy Chinese. You know?" she continues.

Her voice sounds genuinely excited about the Chinese food.

I start to feel better. Chipper, even.

Maybe there *is* some kind of silly explanation for those texts.

Like there was with the gay guy picture. And the lingerie.

"If it's Chinese food you want," I say chivalrously, "then Chinese food you shall have."

"Okay," she says. "So... what time?"

I want to leave now. The heavy paranoia that's been hanging around me is dissipating, as silly as that sounds. Just the sound of her chipper voice has done it.

"I can't get out of here until seven... you want to meet me there at 7:30?"

"It's a date," she says.

Her voice is like the purr of a cat in my ears.

"I love you," I say.

"Love you, too, hot stuff."

"Bye."

"Bye."

I hang up, my heart mending itself as fast as it can from all of my crazy ideas.

And then her text messages hit me hard again.

You just have to watch.

And just like that, I'm plunging in a downward spiral again.

5: CHINESE

I'm there before her. I look at my watch and frown, my stomach twisting. God, like a first date.

It's 7:21.

I exhale and slam a cup of hot tea, which causes the owner and waitress, Jin, to frown at me. "No more than two cups," she says, as she pours me another. "Give you bad stomach."

I order a beer.

I wait.

Two more couples come through the door and sit down for their dates. One couple is young, still chirruping to each other. They sit on the same side of the booth and cuddle.

The other couple is older and they barely talk. They raise their menus like walls between them.

At 7:35 the door swings open. Brooke bounces into the booth and pushes her hair from her face. She looks around. "Great. This is great. It's perfect. Man, I'm so tired of dressing up all the time."

Another stab of discomfort hits me in the gut, but I set it aside for the moment and try to get the ball rolling with some quality time.

"Want something to drink?" I say. "Plum wine or something?"

Brooke wrinkles her nose. "Too sweet."

This devastates me for some reason.

Brooke always likes plum wine. I know because I found it disgusting, myself. In fact, she always likes extremely sweet things, and back when she was quite the party-girl, she claimed that if she went a day without drinking she had to eat like six bags of candy.

"You having a beer?" she says, pointing her fingers at my bottle. "Oooh. Tsingtao. The choice of champions."

The owner shuffles over. "Hey," Brooke says sweetly. "Do you have San Miguel?"

This question perplexes me, but it seems to delight Jin. "Ah, you know San Miguel," she says. She's elated. Then, with a suddenness I find common among Chinese women, her face goes serious. "We don't have. You want Tsingtao?"

“Sure.”

In the meantime, I watch all this, thinking about how Brooke is someone I don’t know so well anymore.

“San Miguel?” I say.

“I had it Hong Kong,” she says nonchalantly.

Of course.

“So?” she says, settling into the booth. “What’s good here?”

*

“I feel like I haven’t seen you forever,” I say, when Jin sets our plates down. Brooke orders her food in Chinese and makes Jin smile and laugh and they talk about Hong Kong for practically ten minutes, to the chagrin of everyone else in the restaurant.

Brooke points her chopsticks down in her noodles and cocks her head a little as she twists.

“It’s only been a week,” she says.

I shrug. “No, it’s not that, I just mean... I never really get to hang out with you anymore.”

She twists her noodles up coolly and smiles, although it seems like the smile is more for the noodles than for me. “It’s just another year,” she says. It takes me a moment to realize she means, at her job.

There is another pause.

Brooke is really taking down this Chinese food. I watch her like she’s a stranger across from me. In some ways, she is.

But I have an agenda, and I’m going to get to it.

“So... how *was* your trip?” I ask. “I didn’t get to ask.”

Brooke looks up at me and sort of laughs. “You *never* ask,” she says. She smiles. “At least, not about the *trip*.”

Fair enough.

“Well, that’s sort of what, um... I’ve been thinking about,” I say. “I don’t really know what’s going on with you.”

Brooke looks down at her noodles. She clears her throat. I can’t tell how she feels, but something about what I’ve just said has caused a serious change in her.

“Well... it was, uh... gosh, there isn’t much to tell about it.”

I stare at her. She's looking into her food and winding her noodles around and around.

"Nothing to tell? Come on. I'm dying to know what's on Cyprus. What did you do the whole time?"

Brooke looks quickly out at the restaurant, and I think I see her swallow hard.

She puts her hand to her throat and coughs. "Man," she says. "I got... I need some... water..."

She holds up a hand to flag down Jin.

"Excuse me," she croaks, and it's this really dramatic croak that sounds incredibly fake, "Can I get some water?"

When she turns to me, she looks at me briefly, and her eyes are watering. Then she looks down at her food. "I think I have a chili pepper stuck to my tonsils," she says.

I nudge my cup of cold tea toward her. "That's cold," I say.

She stares at it like I've handed her a dead fish.

I don't know why, but now I'm sure I'm onto something.

I stab my noodles and wind them around dramatically. "So, really, I really do want to know. Is the place, like, all old buildings, or is it more like, say, Dubai?"

Brooke takes the tea and gulps it down.

I stare at her.

"Uh... it's kind of a cross," she says vaguely.

"And so, did you... I dunno, go shopping? Or to the beach? You had a lot of free time, right? What did you do with all that time?"

Brooke's calm, flight-attendant face is plastered on tightly, but I can see that beneath it, something is shaking apart. Her eyes are wet, and her pupils have consumed the smokey blue of her eyes.

"Shopping," she says weakly. "A little."

I stab my noodles. I keep my eyes right on hers. "Any parties? Anything like that?"

A flicker of alarm passes over her face.

She's so busted, and she knows it. But Brooke's quick to recuperate. She takes a slow, deep breath. I can see that she's calculating her answer, scanning her memories to find out how much I know or don't know.

Jin sets the water down and pats Brooke on the back as she leaves for another table. She reaches for the water, and brings it to her lips. She tips

some ice into her mouth and crunches it up, then looks down in her lap to smooth her napkin. “Uh... yeah. I went to a party actually. How’d you know?”

“Oh,” I say, yelling a little louder than I mean to. “Isn’t that a coincidence. I was just guessing.”

Brooke’s eyes shoot back up to look at me.

“And... what did you do at this party?”

Now, I’ve got her, because a stain of red is creeping up from the back of her neck toward her jawline, which is set tight.

There is a silence while we stare at each other. Brooke’s face is turning pink as the fingers of this flush crawl over her skin. I see a muscle strain in her jaw.

“Pin the tail on the donkey?” I offer.

My own hand is shaking, I notice, as I lift the noodles to bring them to my mouth. I set them back down. This is no time to appear as flustered as I feel.

Brooke looks down suddenly. She throws her napkin aside. At that moment, Jin passes by again.

“Everything okay?” she says.

Brooke looks at her and smiles. Fakely. Lips together. “It’s great,” she says. “I just... need to go to the bathroom.”

She gets up and walks to the bathroom. I sip my beer.

She’s in there forever.

When she comes out, I’ve paid for the bill, because I already know what she’s going to say.

“I feel a little... sick...” she says. Her eyes scan the boxed meal, and another flash of fear rolls over her face. She darts a glance at me and then back at the table. “Oh, okay,” she says.

“You okay to drive?” I say.

Brooke nods. I follow her home, thinking about what I will do to make sure she doesn’t weasel her way out of this conversation. Something is definitely up with her, and I’ve got her.

We get home at almost the same time. She walks through the house, and I follow her, closely. When we get to the bedroom, we’re standing in the darkness and Brooke stops. She turns her head slightly toward me.

I move in to kiss her. It’s a calculated move; I already know this isn’t going anywhere. I want to force her hand. She turns her head away and

mumbles something about being tired.

She flips on a light when she gets to the bathroom and I hear her start the shower water.

I strip down to my boxers, and walk into the bathroom.

Brooke looks at me in alarm, her jeans off and her hands moving in her shirt to take it off.

“Mind if I join you?” I say.

I know that my tone is menacing. Brooke knows it, too. And it’s freaking her out, because it’s not a tone I’ve ever used.

She pulls off her shirt, and folds it neatly with her ruthless snap. She moves past me to set it on the counter. Her lips have drawn together in a line so tight her upper lip has disappeared. “You obviously have something to say,” she says quietly. “So why don’t you say it?”

I give my boxers a snap. “Huh? I don’t know what you mean, Brooke _.”

“Oh cut the shit,” she snaps. “What? What is it? Obviously you’ve got some kind of problem with this trip to Cyprus so why don’t you just say what it is?”

I am overtaken by a sudden rage. It’s all-consuming. I really have a desire to grab her by the throat and push her back against the wall.

I clench my fist.

“You know what I have a problem with, Brooke? Finding mysterious lingerie in your suitcase. Not being able to get a hold of you.”

Brooke is smirking, and her mouth is open to say something.

The rage closes in around me. I lose it.

“And you know what else? This!” I shove past her, down the hall, out to her purse, from which I grab the phone with such a grip that I’m almost worried I’ll crush it.

I’m flying back to the room, telling myself to calm down. I’m so mad that spit comes out of my mouth when I hold the phone up and yell: “I have a problem with this! These messages, from your little friend Micah. These... these messages, while you’re in Cyprus, by the way, where you supposedly couldn’t even send me a text!”

Brooke is staring at me now, and she looks terrified.

I open her phone and get to the messages from Micah.

“All you have to do is watch,” I read off.

And then I look at her.

“Well?” I say.

Brooke’s face is totally white.

She shakes her head. Then she points a finger at the phone. “That’s not what you think,” she says.

Her voice is weak and unconvincing, and it’s as devastating as if she’d stabbed me right through the heart.

“No?” I say. I fold my arms. “Why don’t you tell me what it is, then?”

Brooke is infuriatingly silent. Her eyes get wet with welling tears, and I make a silent vow not to fall for that.

She pushes her hair up with both hands, away from her forehead, where strands of it have started to fall. “It’s just... God, it’s just Micah, she’s up to her stuff. It’s a joke, that’s all. We play it all the time.”

Brooke’s expression has changed suddenly. She has new enthusiasm for this latest explanation.

“We have some client, right, who’s putting the moves on us, and we send text messages like there’s something going on. It’s... not what it looks like. It’s just a game. Like the game *we* play.”

I stare at her, and then I turn my attention back to the phone.

She charges at me and snatches the phone out of my hand. “What are you doing looking at my phone, anyway?” she says.

I feel like I’ve been slapped. I’m trying to figure out if what she’s saying is even possible. Could the messages read that way? All as a joke?

Brooke is getting into her phone, tapping away. She has her back to me.

Is *she* checking her messages now? Is she lying, and trying to see if her story makes sense? Or is she after something else... deleting evidence?

I want to grab the phone from her hand, but I hold myself back. That would be insane, an insane thing to do.

Brooke turns to me, and her eyes are on fire. “Why did you go through my messages?” she snaps. She waves the phone around. “Have you been snooping around in everything else, too?”

I feel the sudden, hopeless sensation of having an argument turn back around on me. Something I was so sure of winning, and now I’m somehow the one who looks like a jerk.

Brooke tosses her phone on the bed. Then she stomps down the hallway and back. She throws her purse on the bed, dumping the contents out first by shaking it upside down.

“There!” she yells. “There’s all my stuff. Go through it, see what you can dig up!”

Then she heads down the hall and into the spare bedroom, slamming the door.

I sit down on the bed. I pick up the phone – unabashedly – and open it up. I re-read the messages. I think of her explanation.

I feel like a heel.

I lie back on the bed and stare at the ceiling.

Is it possible I’ve just been an asshole? Not trusting my wife? Letting my imagination run away with me?

I conclude that that is, indeed, entirely possible.

I’m relieved, in many ways. But now Brooke is pissed at me.

I rub my face and think back over the evening, seeing it all in a new light. A light in which I’m an asshole husband who hasn’t spent enough time with his wife. I think about the couples at the restaurant: the young couple, fresh and still in love, pawing at each other all through the meal. The older couple, silent and distant.

I think about how I don’t know things about Brooke and her trips. Like that she learned some Chinese, or had some kind of beer. I’m always so interested in what interests me.

And now, I think with a really heavy feeling, I have to go apologize.

6: APOLOGIES

I hear Brooke leave the guest bedroom and go into the kitchen.

I go down the hallway and catch her pouring herself a glass of wine. She's found some old clothes in the guest bedroom and I can't help but notice she looks incredibly sexy in the worn shirt and the panties she found. She glares at me, and sweeps away to the sun room attached to the back porch.

I take a deep breath, pour my own wine even though I don't want it, and follow her.

She shoots daggers at me when I open the door.

"Listen," I say, plunging right in. "I'm... I shouldn't have done that. I feel like an asshole."

Brooke is silent. She wraps her hands around the wine and shivers, even though it's quite warm outside. She squints at the horizon through the windows overlooking our small yard, which lets out into a field.

I sit down in a chair across from her. "Look, this is hard for me to say," I begin. "So... it might come out wrong. What I did was a bad thing to do. I just... I got caught up in this job, in... you were going to all these exotic places, and then we had our game, and it just made my imagination go wild. Then there was the thing with the lingerie, and then you went to Cyprus... I know I should trust you. I *do* trust you."

I'm unable to keep looking at her, because she looks so disappointed in me.

"I do trust you Brooke, I know it doesn't seem like it because of what I've done, but..." I sigh. This is really hard to say. The words stick in my mouth but I get them out. "I guess I just feel a little insecure. You're beautiful, you're around all these rich people... I can't help it. My mind went to the worst possible place and it was wrong. But I hope you'll forgive me."

I am looking at the fence in our backyard. I don't know what to expect from Brooke after this confession, but it was pretty hard to choke out. I'm hoping she'll forgive me, hoping I don't have to take too much humiliating lecturing from her.

What I'm not expecting is what happens next.

Brooke let's out an incredibly wet, choking, sob.

She puts her hands to her face and leans forward, almost like she's going to fall out of the chair.

My first thought is actually that she's been hit in the face with something, because that's what it looks like.

I put my arms on her forearms and push her back into the chair. No sound is coming out of her mouth, but her face is red as a beet. A silent cry, like a child does when she's really hurt.

"Brooke," I say, deeply concerned. "What is it?"

I try to pull on her hands, to see the injury I'm now convinced she has to her face. I've totally forgotten the context of this outburst or my own guilt. I really think she's hurt.

Brooke curls up with surprising force, her head toward her knees, her whole abdomen crunching up until she's making a small ball.

"Honey?" I say. "Are you okay?" When she doesn't answer I get loud. "Brooke! Tell me what happened!"

Brooke shakes her head on her lap and let's out a sob. Or a wail.

She lifts her head. She's shaking it back and forth.

A feeling of doom sinks over me, from the crown of my head down, like being covered in tar. Even before she blubbers:

"I can't lie to you anymore."

I let go of her wrist, which I've been holding onto as though to take her pulse. I rise up just enough to get myself into the chair, and I collapse into it.

Brooke is looking at me, and her expression is pathetic. But gone is any doubt, any confusion about what it means.

She's very sorry, that much is clear. She didn't mean to do it, and she feels awful.

But she's *done something*, and now the tables are turned again.

I stare at her, my mouth open.

Brooke wipes her eyes. She looks down at her feet. "First of all, you have to know... things just got out of hand. It isn't like... it isn't what you're thinking, some kind of, I don't know, affair."

She takes a deep breath and sort of rolls her eyes skyward.

My guts plummet through me to the floor, or at least it feels that way. I can hear a vague ringing in my ears. My heart has picked up the pace and it seems ready to start beating faster and faster, until I have a heart attack.

Brooke looks at her hands.

“Micah does this all the time. She’s, uh... she’s actually, you know... sort of a prostitute. I guess. Or, no that’s not really fair. She hooks up with guys on flights, and she gets a lot of money for it.”

Brooke looks at me, right in the eye, just for emphasis. “*A lot of money.*”

My stomach has turned to pure icy bile.

I have nothing to say, so I just keep looking at her.

She twists her hands together.

“So, Micah is on the crew for Andrei Risolov’s private jet. And that’s... you know, pretty much all she does. The jet use gets split up by the whole family and some friends, and one of these guys is sort of, a um, regular ‘client’ of hers. She spends the week with him, they go to parties, she’s sort of a... an escort, while he’s there.”

There is a long pause.

“Where do you come in with this story?” I say coldly.

Brooke twists her hands some more. “So... we went to this party, and Micah gets pretty high, she comes over and she tells me that Konstantin, this guy, has a proposition for me. And it’s... I’m like, no way, right? I was already getting nervous about this guy on the flight, okay? He’s obviously really into having sex with everyone he sees. He asked me to come ‘watch a movie’ with him on the flight, and so of course I was like, no way. So... Micah comes over and she tells me this, and I tell her I’m outta there. I don’t even hear what it is. And I go home.”

I keep looking at her with a blank expression, Now the big freeze that has taken over my abdomen is spreading all over me.

Yet I find myself pining for the next little bit. The way I do when we play our game. I can feel the excitement building up in my groin, the queasy, unnerved erection threatening to grow. I’m repulsed and yet I’m hungry for more at the same time.

I envision this party, my wife in some skimpy dress, Micah – who I see as the blonde Swedish-looking girl I saw at the Hilton airport, even though I know she can’t possibly be – and the two of them whispering all these sordid details to each other. Close together, their lips almost touching.

“So what happened next?” I say, when she stares at her hands for too long.

She looks to the side, and then back at her lap. “We went to another party the next day, this one’s on a yacht. So it’s overnight, which I didn’t know at the outset. Overnight and we stop at this island where some friend has this crazy house with a pool. And they are having... like, the most amazing party I’ve ever seen.”

I have a thought, suddenly, a hopeful thought, that maybe this is just part of our game. That she’s just building this up, like she always does, and then she’s going to say: just kidding.

I savor the idea, and I actually start to get into it as she talks some more.

“So Micah is like, listen, this guy is really interested in doing this, and he’s willing to throw down some serious cash for it. All he wants you to do is... you know, show up, and watch.”

Brooke sighs. “And I laugh, right, because... yeah, right. That’s just what they say and then next thing you know, you’re in on it. So I say no, and then I’m really uncomfortable at this party, because those guys are always walking around and looking at me. And then... so...” she sighs. “So I end up taking this pill, to calm myself down. Because, um...”

“Whoa,” I say. “You ‘end up’ taking a pill? Like what? Ecstasy?”

Brooke looks at me. Her face is crumpling.

“Brooke?”

She shakes her head again. “Okay... so this is the part that, uh... I don’t know. I was really drunk, and Micah kept coming over and dancing with me. She was like, it’s no big deal, let’s just forget about it and have a good time, I’m sorry I put this pressure on you, it’s totally cool. And then we started dancing, and I got drunk, I was having a good time... and then she had this pill. And, um...”

“You took it,” I finish for her.

Brooke blushes, so I suppose there’s more to this part than she’s letting on. My mind quickly goes to an image of her sucking the pill off of Micah’s tongue, which is probably very close to what happened.

“And then?” I prompt.

Brooke lifts her eyes. “and then... I exercised some bad judgment.”

She looks at her hands again.

“Tell me,” I say.

She shrugs. “It was just like that,” she says. “Just watching. That’s all it was. I sat there, and she did her thing, and I didn’t get involved.”

I raise my eyebrows.

I picture my wife, “sitting there,” while Micah “did her thing,” and I get an erection.

“So you just sat there... what? Clothed? Watching them have sex?”

Brooke shakes her head again, quickly. Another stain of red creeps across her cheek.

I lean forward onto my knees. “So how did it go?” I say. “Tell me all the details.”

Brooke looks at me and shakes her head again. “I don’t want to,” she says. She blinks, and a tear falls down her face.

I’m torn between feeling sorry for her, being aroused, and wanting to slap her.

“Tell me all the details,” I say. “You’re the one who made the bad decision. Now you can at least tell me what happened.”

I feel a little bad about the perversion of what I’m actually after. The thrill I’m seeking. A little bit of it is to make her humiliate herself. I’m also angry, so I kind of want to punish her, too.

This is all mixed up but I know one thing: I’m going to get these details out of her one way or the other.

“Start with what you were wearing,” I say coldly.

Brooke sniffs. She rubs her nose. When she looks at me, she sees I’m not letting her off the hook.

“My underwear,” she says.

I narrow my eyes.

“My underwear at first and then... I took it off. But there was no touching. Not, uh, from him.”

Psst. My cock is rock hard like it has never been before. In my mind, Micah and Brooke are playing tongue hockey, sweaty and shiny against each other. Their pink tongues darting around each other’s mouths, wet and sticky. Maybe Micah even has this guy’s cock in her pussy while they do it.

I suck in my breath. “So you’re there in your underwear. Where did you sit?”

Brooke sees now that I want to hear the details, that I want them because they turn me on. However angry I am at her, I want to hear about it.

“On a.. kind of a couch. And they were on a bed. I was maybe three feet away.”

“Sitting?”

She nods. She's having a hard time looking at me, and that's how I know this isn't part of a game she's playing.

Unless she's the greatest actress in the world. Which is always a possibility with Brooke.

"So tell me," I say. "What happened?"

"Um... so I just sat there. And the guy got on the bed -"

"In his clothes? Or not?"

Brooke blushes. "He was... you know. Naked."

"And Micah?"

Brooke purses her lips together. "She had her underwear on, like me."

I suddenly remember the lingerie, make a mental note that I need to come back to that topic, and keep plowing ahead.

"Keep talking," I say.

"Well... it was just... like that, you know, um... Micah climbed up on top of him and did a strip tease, and then she took off her bra, and started to give this guy a blowjob. And I..."

I picture my wife sitting primly on a couch, her underwear barely covering her, watching Micah's mouth slurp up some guy's huge dick. I can almost feel the burn on her skin by looking at her red cheeks.

"So how did you get your clothes off?" I say.

Brooke takes a deep breath and exhales. She looks at her knees again. She doesn't want to tell me, and I don't want to let up.

"I want the whole truth Brooke," I say.

I think: *you're the one who screwed up here.*

I'm enjoying, as perverse as it is, that she feels bad.

"Brooke?" I prompt her, when she doesn't say anything.

"So he is getting, um, you know, a blowjob from Micah, and -"

"How did you feel while you were watching him?"

Brooke lifts her eyes and meets mine for a moment. Her cheeks turn even more crimson. She looks away. "It was, um..." She exhales sharply. "I kind of... it turned me on a little. Honestly."

It turns me on a little too. Honestly.

"So then what?"

"So then he looks over at me. Like, right at me, and Micah's just sucking on his cock. And he says: "'You, I want to see your...' You know."

I look at my wife. "No," I say. "I don't know."

"He wanted to see my tits."

“And so,” I say. “You just, what? Stood up and took your bra off?”

Brooke nods and looks at her hands again. “It was just... I got caught up in the moment.” Another tear wells up and slides down her cheek.

I suck in my breath, picturing the scene. I wonder if she stood up awkwardly, the way she’s telling the story now. If she felt some remorse, like she seems to now, and sort of peeled her clothes off uncertainly.

Or if she acted like a whore, and did a little dance, moving her hips seductively.

“And so, then what?”

Brooke bites her lip. “I don’t... I don’t really know. It...”

I lean toward her. I’m actually surprising myself, being so insistent. “Well, you’re standing there naked, and he’s getting his dick sucked and looking at you, so what did you do next?”

Brooke inhales.

“The truth, Brooke. Tell me everything that happened.”

She brings her fingers to her mouth. “I didn’t know what to do, so I just stood there, and he kept looking at me, you know, his eyes all over me, and then... he just... you know, came.”

“In Micah’s mouth?”

Brooke nods.

“Did she swallow?”

Her cheeks burn anew. She nods.

“And what did you do after that?”

Brooke hugs herself. “So, well... then suddenly I was like, coming down off the high I was on, so I grabbed my stuff and I left and went back out to a bathroom and got dressed.”

I read her face. It looks like she’s telling the truth.

I guess.

And I’m turned on as hell.

“Did it turn you on?” I ask her quietly.

She looks afraid to answer the question.

Since she doesn’t say anything, I scoot the chair I’m on toward her and reach for her knees. She looks a little startled, and she pushes her knees together. I keep prying them open, until she relents. My fingers move up the length of her thigh, under the long shirt, to the fabric that covers her pussy. And I find the material between her legs soaked through.

Just as I had expected.

I move in on her, taking her panties off with two hands until they pass her knees and then pushing her legs up toward her face. Brooke is thin and flexible, so this is not a problem, and soon I have her suspended by the ankles, her pussy swollen and glistening and spread open beneath them.

I tug my boxer shorts down and free my cock, which is as hard as her pussy is wet.

I put a knee on either side of her and my cock sinks right into her wet flesh, making her clit dart under the crown and sliding between her lips without going inside of her. Her body is hot and the feel of her flesh, wet with all her excitement from thinking about the very bad thing she did, almost sends me over the edge by itself.

I get lined up with her sopping hole and push inside of her. I've never fucked her like this, in such a whoreish fashion, like she's a rubber doll or something. I pay little attention to her needs this time, I'm so hungry to satisfy my own; to punish her a little, to fill her up with my cum, to fuck out the images I have of her stripping down – for real – for a total stranger who combed her naked body with eyes while another woman slurped on his cock.

But Brooke is, perhaps, off in her own little world, because she makes a lot of noise and I feel her pussy pulsing around me as she comes, just before my own cum boils up and spurts inside of her. Her pussy sloshes with sloppy sucking sounds that send quivers through my prick as I shoot the final drops inside of her.

I lean against her for a moment, and then she squirms to get a leg out of her twisted panties and drop her limbs to the side, and my cock slithers out of her stuffed pussy. The scent of sex is hanging heavy in the air.

As my climax subsides, I start to feel uncomfortable with what we've done: a cold burn in my chest starts to grip me. I fall down to the rug, pulling my boxers up as I do. The liquid on my balls starts to cool.

I lean my forearms on my knees and brush a hand through my hair. Brooke pulls her panties up and then pulls her knees up to her chin. She looks more fragile than usual. Expectant.

I decide to break the ice that is forming again between us.

“Is that it, Brooke? The whole truth?”

She moves her head up and down, drawing her lips along the top of her knee.

Then:

“Well...” she says. “There’s only one more thing.”

My gut twists, but I meet her eye. I’m ready for it.

“He paid me for it. On the flight back. And, um... he said I could come back any time. And then he like, drew his fingers up and down the back of my leg.”

I get shivers imagining this scene.

We look at each other in silence. I don’t know what Brooke is thinking, and I’m not sure I want to ask her. I’m trying hard to think about how I should be angry, how I should be disturbed. But what I really feel is arousal, even though I just fucked, broiling at the base of my cock.

And then Brooke says quietly:

“He pays Micah almost \$20K.”

She’s looking at me with that same expectant look.

What does she want me to say? I wonder.

What *do* I want to say?

I wait, and it becomes evident that Brooke has put the ball in my court. My stomach twists again.

“And so... what? You want to do it again?”

Brooke’s eyes flash. She rubs her lips on her knee some more. Her eyes wander all over the room.

“I don’t know,” she says finally. “It’s... a lot of money.”

It’s a lot of money.

“It’s not just the money,” I say.

Brooke brings her eyes back to meet mine. “No.”

Something simmers in the air between us. My cock is getting thick again, and I can scarcely believe it.

“If you were to do it,” I say, and I’m having a little trouble catching my breath. A sensation like vertigo is gripping my mind, probably because all the blood in my body is servicing my cock as my thoughts strain forward into the future. “We’d have to have some rules.”

I can see that Brooke is excited that I’ve responded this way, rather than just shutting it down, and she’s trying to keep her calm.

“Okay,” she says, her voice shaky. “Like what?”

Like what, indeed.

Brooke drops her legs to the floor and parts them. Her panties have soaked through with my draining cum and her own excitement.

“You tell me everything,” I say. “Every detail.”

Brooke's cheeks flush a little. She bites her lip. "Okay," she says. "It's just... you know, kind of hard. To, um... get the details, exactly, you know, right."

"I'm sure you'll manage," I say.

Brooke gives me a look, a slow blink to let me know that indeed she will.

"And it's just this one guy. This one excursion. For the money."

She nods again.

Then she slides down to the floor. She is wearing a thin pajama made of a t-shirt material that is largely see-through, and her nipples are erect at the top of her well-formed breasts. I slide my hands under her shirt and roll them between my fingers as she squirms. "And what about limits?" she says.

She is sliding her panties down to her knees again. They are so wet they roll up and make a heavy sound as they reach the floor.

I squint, confused. My mind is on her nipples between my fingers, the scent of her pussy, her lean thighs.

"On what I do," she explains. "Any limits?"

"Oh God, Brooke," I say, my mind spinning.

She pushes me back onto the floor and I lie down. I feel her hands pulling my boxers down.

Then I feel her hand gripping my cock at the base, and her hot breath against the length of my prick as she moves her mouth around my shaft, almost nuzzling, murmuring to me in a low voice. Almost like she's speaking to my dick, her breath moist and hot against my skin. "Like, can I do anything, anything at all? Or is there something you don't want me to do?"

She flicks her tongue at the crown of my cock. I look down and her eyes meet mine, their sexy color hovering over her puffy lips as they close around my dick.

My mind is too distracted to think of things I would *not* like her to do with this guy, though I try hard. Surely I don't want... I don't want...

Brooke begins to suck on my cock and all of my thoughts fall to pieces. I look at the ceiling to try and make things last a little longer, while her lips and her hot, wet mouth slide up and down the length of my shaft. She releases her hand and gets the whole thing in her mouth. I feel her

lower lip against my ball sack, a little tightness as she sucks and massages my cock with her mouth.

I put my hand in her silky hair and shudder as she works her way back up to the crown and releases my cock with a sloppy pop. Her hand moves up and down my shaft.

She climbs on top of me, straddling me, and pulls her shirt up and over her head. I stare up at her in her full glory, the scent of her pussy hovering just above my pelvis. Her gash is a little swollen, the red interior of her soft white slit protruding just a little. I am about to grab her thigh and probe her pussy with my thumb, when she guides my cock to her slit.

She embeds just the crown in the hot, sticky-wet flesh of her pussy. I feel the silky softness between her outer lips and her tumid clit, and then the tip of my dick is against her clit. She begins to stroke herself with the head of my cock.

I put my head on my hands to lift up and look at the sight of her masturbating with my dick. Her pussy is sloshing and squelching with every movement of my cock, and against my hips I can feel her thighs tightening. Her abdomen is rolling in little waves, her mouth parted, as she gets closer and closer to an orgasm.

“Oh, God,” she breathes softly. Her whole body quivers, then seizes, and she gasps. I see a wave of goosebumps roll along her arm and up to her neck.

She seems to be frozen, but I can’t wait for her to move. I grab her hips and pull her body down, sheathing my cock in her hot flesh. Her pulsing pussy oozes cum all over my balls. I push up, getting as deep inside of her as I can.

“Oh!” she says, and she shifts her weight. I know she’s tender after coming, but I give her no relief. I move my hand to her gash and push my thumb into her soaked flesh to find her clit. Her pussy clenches around me and her eyes, half-closed until now, fly open.

I use my other hand to grab her ass and keep her on top of me even as she squirms in over-excited discomfort. “Oh, God,” she says, though her words are choppy and barely intelligible. She’s so wet that her thighs are sliding on top of mine in all of her slick juices.

“Ride my cock,” I say.

“My... I can’t... I’m too...”

“Ride it,” I insist. “Show me what a good little slut you can be. You wouldn’t give up for Konstantin. Not if he was paying you for it. So show me what you can do.”

My cock throbs inside of her pussy.

She looks down at me now, and her face has the expression she gets when I give her a challenge. There aren’t many that Brooke is interested in. But this one: yes.

She starts to buck on top of me. Her mouth is open and she is moaning as she does. At first her discomfort is evident.

She starts to bounce on top of me, and I have no idea where to look: her bouncing tits, too small to slap against her chest as they rise and fall with each hop she takes on my cock? Or my own shaft, wet and slimy, being slurped up and then spat out by her rising and falling pussy, sticky crinkles marking each thrust?

I grip her ass and try hard not to go over the edge before she comes again. She starts to grind against me, and now I feel that her own excitement is building again.

It’s a long, sweaty, fuck from there. Her skin has a sheen of sweat and we both teeter close to an orgasm for a painfully delicious time, spent by all the fucking we’ve already done. I hold on when I get close. “Come again for me,” I say, pushing against her clit as she grinds against my balls.

Her eyes get wide as a final orgasm seizes her body. I come moments later, my whole body racked by the stratospheric heights of it.

Brooke collapses, crumpling like a deflated blow-up doll to the left of me. I turn to her to make sure she’s okay. Her eyelashes flutter and I pull her close to my chest.

It’s a very long time – irresponsibly so, I vaguely realize, because it’s a workday – before we both come back down to Earth.

Brooke breaks the reverie by pushing up to her elbow and looking at me.

She laughs.

“Was that for real?” she says.

“That was hot,” I say.

Brooke hesitates. “But, I mean: was that for real, like... you know. We’re actually going to do this?”

I sit up on my elbows.

“Uh... so look, I don’t want to say something here that’s... not the right thing. I just want to be honest.”

Brooke nodded. “Me, too.”

“So...”

She smiles. “So...” she echoes. Then we laugh.

“Okay spit it out at the count of three,” she says.

Okay... wait, what?” I say. “what am I spitting out?”

Brooke looks at me, and her eyes burn right through my soul.

“If we’re really going to do this. For real,” she says.

Another red-hot poker rams through my chest.

She holds up her fingers.

One.

Two.

Three.

“For real.”

“Yes.”

7: WAITING GAME

The decision made, oddly enough, it is easy to let go of worrying about it. We don't even really talk about it for the next few weeks.

Brooke flies one quick trip to New York, a corporate gig with about twenty passengers. I am remarkably un-fazed by this trip. She calls me at night, tells me about what she ate for dinner and a funny-looking dog she saw on the street (Brooke delights in these things) and we don't even trade the usual innuendo-laden comments and jokes.

Which is fine: I feel as much anticipation as I normally do when Brooke is away, but now it's for something else, something more substantive. I find that all of my paranoia has eased, and I wonder why.

She has the next week off. She dedicates the time to going on long runs and cooking, which is nice. I have a lot of balls in the air at work, and it's very, very pleasant to come home to a nice meal. And to Brooke.

And then one day I come home. The house smells wonderful; she's cooked a magnificent mushroom soup and a pasta dish. But she has a strange energy when I come home; for the past week she's been relaxed, easy-going. Now she's humming around the kitchen and talking a mile a minute about how she made the soup.

I sense something is up, and I think I know what it is. That same adrenaline-soaked fist seizes my stomach and I set my briefcase down on a dining-table chair and look at her as she buzzes around. She's moving with such an asymmetric energy that her hands shake as she tastes the soup.

"... and then you have to do this thing with mushrooms, which I never knew about before, and that's to let them *slowly* braise until they're browned but still juicy, who knew? -"

"Brooke," I say.

She turns to me. Spoon in mid-air. "Huh?"

"What's up?" I coax.

She sets the spoon into the soup. "No, um. Yeah, nothing... just..."

I look at her with an expression of patience, but lower my chin. *Get on with it*, my looks says.

She comes to the island in the middle of the kitchen and folds her hands together, then pulls them apart, crosses them the opposite way, and

moves them nervously. “Um... I have a flight tomorrow.”

Heat and iciness cascade over me, and my heart feels like it’s going to jump out of my chest.

“A flight with...”

She looks up at me. “Konstantin. The... um... you know. Russian guy.”

This is it. It’s what we’ve planned, what I’ve been waiting for. It’s what I thought had kept me calm the past two weeks.

But it’s suddenly too much. My heart is racing, which is something I hate. My stomach feels like it’s been tied into a knot and a rat is chewing through it. My palms start to sweat.

What are we doing? What have I agreed to?

I look at Brooke, my pretty, lovely, small-boned wife. Brooke, the sexy party-girl. Brooke, who is all mine.

Brooke, who has agreed to basically be a prostitute.

What am I talking about, basically?

What she has agreed to do is, by definition, prostitution.

And I am an officer of the court.

“Brooke,” I say.

She flutters her eyes at me. “I know,” she says, and it really does seem like she does. She lets out a sharp exhale. With the back of her fingers she pushes some stray strands of hair from her forehead and presses her lips together. “Now that it’s real, I’m... I dunno.” She looks at me. “Is this crazy?”

I want to say, simply, “yes.” Because it is. What we are considering doing is crazy.

But inside of me there is something else. I know the feeling: it’s the same impulse that has driven me, in my life, to do some of the stupidest things I’ve ever done. The same hot asphyxia that made me jump off Jimmy Wright’s roof, two stories, into his pool about twenty feet out, after doing some questionable math (because Claire Kaplan was watching). The same fingers tapping on my chest that made me, in one glorious courtroom drama, break all rules and ask a question I didn’t know the answer to in the hopes of slamming the verdict in my direction. The electric pull that made me follow Brooke out of my office on what ostensibly would have been the last time I’d ever see her, and ask her out, even though she was (and is) way, way out of my league.

It's a feeling that, in the past five or six years (maybe more), I've come to believe no longer affected me. I have convinced myself that I'm too middle-aged, too responsible, to ever feel this again.

But here I am, standing in my own kitchen, and it has me by the balls. It feels *good*.

I step toward Brooke, and she's like the ground rising up to meet me, my legs flailing over the gray cement, the blue of the pool seemingly just out of reach. She's the unknown answer to the question I've asked; the pause that seems to last forever as the witness's face contorts in disbelief and the jury stares. Brooke is herself, walking away down the fluorescent-lit hallways of my old law offices, her brown hair swinging along her shoulders; a girl I have no business being in the same room with, let alone asking out.

"It's crazy," I say. My voice surprises me with its steadiness. "But..."

I leave that hanging there. I don't think Brooke needs any more encouragement than this. I think Brooke can finish the sentence herself.

"What if I chicken out?" she says.

I slide my hands around her waist and pull her close to me. I'm ready to go; my cock has been responding to this moment all along. I know she can feel me against her legs, and I see how it affects her: her pupils swallow a few slivers of her irises, and her breath gets caught in her throat.

I brush her hair, which is persistently falling across her forehead, away. I tuck it behind her ear. "Then you chicken out," I say. "Only do it if you want to do it."

My stomach goes cold again.

Brooke bites her lip.

I kiss her, savoring the uneven shape of her lips, their softness. When I think about how someone else will taste her mouth, my heart feels squeezed but my cock flexes impatiently. I start to walk her backward out of the kitchen.

I remember the soup and her baking pasta as we pass through the doorway, but I don't say anything because we are kissing passionately, taking off each other's clothes. Anyway, I want to see if Brooke will remember, because she always remembers that sort of thing, even in the throes of passion.

She doesn't. We make love, and it is passionate and tender and hot. The soup burns, the pasta incinerates, the smoke detector wakes us from a

peaceful, post-coital slumber.

We order take-out from Jin's; a totally different kind of couple to the one we were only two weeks ago, and to the couples who dot the restaurant. We can barely keep our hands off each other as we wait for her to bring us the bags. And then we go home.

*

"You still never told me why this was in your suitcase," I say, pulling on the racy lingerie that is now folded neatly (and visibly) on the pile of clothes Brooke is placing carefully in her suitcase.

My suspicions are renewed again as I finger the see-through fabric.

Brooke hurries back to the suitcase with her swimsuits and sets them down before snatching the lingerie out of my hand. "Do you still not trust me?" she says, with a smile. "I did tell you, you probably just weren't listening." She unfolds the crumpled lingerie and holds it up. I can see right through the scrap of fabric. "I got this for you, actually," she says. "On my trip to the Cayman Islands."

She pushes her hand through it. "It's really something, isn't it?"

I prop myself up and stare at the lingerie, unable to do the three-dimensional maneuvering in my mind and figure out how it would look on her. Or any woman, for that matter. I cock my head to the side.

"Why was it in your suitcase, then?" I say.

Brooke drops her hands and looks at me. Her expression is one of exasperation.

"Look," she says. "I've told you everything." She holds the lingerie up. "I washed it, accidentally, with my other stuff. I guess it just got stuck to something."

I raise my eyebrows.

"Really," Brooke said. She shakes her head. "Don't ruin the vibe we have going."

We have a good vibe going. I feel like we've re-started our relationship. Last night was fun, exciting, romantic.

It's only now, in the light of day, that I'm again wondering if I'm not doing something stupid.

"Now," Brooke says, a glimmer in her eye. "I *am* going to wear it for someone else."

My stomach lurches and my cock thickens.

“I wonder if I should try it on and see if it’s okay after that wash.”

Brooke muses this last bit aloud, but she’s already walking toward the bathroom with her lingerie. She steps behind the dividing wall and talks as I watch snippets of her elbows and her butt moving in the mirror as she takes off her clothes and puts on the lingerie. “I got this because Hega – she’s the Norwegian girl you thought was Swedish? - she wanted to go to this lingerie shop. She bought so much slutty stuff, I couldn’t believe it.”

Brooke pauses in front of the mirror. I can only see her lean arm, which she’s resting on her hip, and a flash of her hair as she gives it a toss. She turns a little, I suppose to admire herself. My mouth has gone dry.

“Whoa,” she says. She steps out from behind the dividing wall.

I gulp as Brooke slides her fingers under the shiny lace-embroidered edging of the lingerie. The fabric is scant, but it barely matters because almost all of it is see-through. Two lace-edged strips hug her breasts and little more, coming together in a sharp v-shape at her navel. There, the fabric flares out a little over her hips, but disappears again into a sharp v-shape where her gash is. Her nipples are dark circles in the center of the top, and I can see the dark line of her pussy through the bottom.

“Turn around?” I say, my throat dry.

She gives a turn, and reveals the thong back nestled between her round buttocks. It flares at the top of her ass, accentuating the shape of her small rear. There’s not much else to the back of it, just two lacy straps that run over her shoulders to hold up the front.

She turns back around to face me. Again, she runs her hand along the lace. “You would not believe how much this cost,” she says.

I would, but I’m not capable of saying much at the moment.

She turns around again to admire herself in the mirror, while I contemplate the fact that another man will watch her peel that from her body – or do it himself – within the next 72 hours.

She starts to slide it from her body.

“You aren’t going to wear it?” I say.

Brooke turns back to me. “It would show under my blouse,” she says.

I shrug. *So?*

Brooke lets the lingerie drop to the floor and bends over to pick it up. She does it very deliberately, very slowly, to give me a nice view of her gash.

“It’s not professional,” she says. And then she crosses the room with her deliberate, stewardess-slip walk, and opens a drawer.

I watch her remove two pristine white items from the drawer.

“Now, hold on a minute,” I say. “Before you put those on...”

Brooke shakes her head. “I’m almost late. *You’ll* just have to wait.”

She slips into her white underwear and bra set and settles her breasts into the fabric. The lacy bra hugs her like a second skin, plumping her little breasts into delectable creamy mounds.

She walks to the closet and selects two white blouses. One she puts into her suitcase and the other she slips on. It’s short-sleeved and silky, creamy just like her skin. Then she returns to the closet for her skirt. I watch her slip it on, and suddenly she is a hot little number wrapped up as a stewardess. “No tie?” I say, when she locks her suitcase.

She looks back at me. “Not for Konstantin.”

I scoot to the end of the bed. I pull her by the back of the knees toward me. “I love you,” I say.

She plays with my hair. “Are you sure about this?”

I’m looking up at the sweet curve of her breasts, my fingers on the soft backside of her knees. This is *my* wife, and while it’s been fun imagining that someone else has rubbed his cock all over her mouth or plundered her pussy, is that what I really want?

I kiss her wrist. “Sure,” I say.

She leans over and kisses me, and then she straightens up and smooths her uniform.

And then she is gone.

*

Konstantin-something (a Russian name that I cannot pronounce) is taking his family jet to Cyprus again.

I try to put out of my mind all the things I vaguely know about money-laundering and Cyprus and Russians in Cyprus, and focus on the part that interests and terrifies me, personally: my wife getting a big huge tip for being an excellent flight attendant who caters to *all* of Konstantin’s needs.

Brooke confessed to me, the evening before she left, that she had made up the story about her text messages not working because she felt too

guilty about what she was doing and then, what she had done, to call me or contact me. In fact, her phone worked just fine, as evidenced by all of her contacts with Micah.

So she would be in touch with me by the end of the day, potentially. As promised, she texts me in the late evening.

[Brooke]: *Just got settled in. Really tired. Will call you after I sleep.*

She calls the next morning around six.

“Hey,” she says, her voice awake and refreshed.

I’m still groggy. I wipe sleep from my eyes (I fell asleep at the table going over a deposition and intermittently thinking about Brooke). “How are you?”

Brooke laughs at the formality of this question. “It’s good. I’m good. I, um... nothing exciting to report here.”

I feel disappointment and relief splash against each other inside of me. “Oh,” I say flatly. “So no... he didn’t, uh... say anything to you on the plane?”

There is a pause. “Well, not *exactly*,” Brooke says. Her voice is full of innuendo.

“Not exactly,” I repeat. “But...?”

My cock is coming to life.

“Well,” Brooke says, and she lowers her voice. “I told Micah to, you know, let him know that maybe I’m interested in a repeat of, you know. Last time. Only more.”

I breathe into the phone for a moment before I realize I should say something. “Yeah,” I prompt.

“And so... he never said anything, he was, you know doing business most of the flight. But he kept *looking* at me like... I don’t know. Like he was undressing me. Kind of smug and flirtatious at the same time.”

“Anything else?”

“I set a drink down on his table and he took it and swiped his finger over mine.”

I picture it, in high relief, and my cock pulses.

“Okay,” I say. “So... what are you... what are your plans now?”

“I don’t know,” Brooke says cheerfully. “Last time Micah came and asked me if I wanted to go... so, I guess I’ll just wait and see.”

“You think he’s still going to -”

“Oh, yeah,” Brooke says. She sounds 100% confident, so I know that whatever “look” Konstantin is giving her, it’s clear.

Brooke yawns. “Oh, man. Listen, I’m going to go try and get a little time in at the beach before the sun goes away.”

“Is it nice there?”

“It’s actually kind of cool,” she says. “But I want a tan. And a nap.”

I smile. “Okay... Well, stay in touch.”

“Of course.”

“I love you.”

“I love you, too.”

A day goes by, and I get nothing but a text from Brooke.

[Brooke]: *going to the island looks like tomorrow*

I stare at the text. I consider calling her. This little snippet is insufficient to fuel my fantasy, sate my appetite. *How* does she know she’s going to the island tomorrow? Did Konstantin call her? Or is he the kind of man who summons women with a messenger?

Maybe he stopped by himself, to invite her. To really, *really* invite her.

I’m at the courthouse when I get her text, and I have to put it out of my mind the best I can so I don’t end up blowing the whole case I’m there for. As soon as I drop into the seat of my car, though, I take out my phone.

I wonder if I should call her. Then the absurdity of calling my wife from the parking lot of a courthouse to see how her first prostitute experience is going hits me.

I drive home, wondering if I should call or text. What do you text to your wife when she’s being seduced by another man? “How’s it going?”

By the time I arrive home, I still haven’t figured it out.

I sit down with a beer, which I’ve already opened by the time I realize I need something stronger, and stare at my screen. The cursor blinks infuriatingly at me.

Type. Something.

It’s now, I calculate quickly, the middle of the night in Cyprus. Did Brooke mean she was going *today*?

I type:

[Me]: *are you leaving today? Or are you already there?*

But I'm left without an answer. All night, the whole night filled with fantasy and nightmare, scenarios playing out in my mind, sudden seizures of fear in which I think I've made the wrong decision.

At 4am I get another message.

[Brooke]: *sorry. Out all night just back from breakfast. Today.*

I'm wide awake. I read and re-read. *Out all night.*

Out all night with Konstantin? With Micah? All three of them?

And then I start thinking about all the other people who are surely on this trip. The pilot. Konstantin's friends. Family members. Business associates. All of them "out all night" with my wife.

Another text rattles my phone.

It's a media message.

I look at the picture. It's a selfie of Brooke.

She has big, dark sunglasses on, and she looks incredibly glamorous. Her lips are in a model-like pout – but this is something Brooke does very well, without looking silly like a duck. She has the kind of lips that she barely needs to do anything with.

She's leaning on what appears to be the very expensive, teak railing of a boat. Aquamarine water sparkles behind her.

She's wearing a black bikini. I can only see her chest; the skimpy suit frames her breasts nicely and her skin has an almond toast to it.

She looks all at once exactly, and nothing, like my wife.

A message appears as I'm staring at the picture.

[Brooke]: *I dont know. Think I can lure him in?*

I make an audible sound as it feels like I just got hit in the stomach. What do I type? What do I say?

[Me]: *you look like a model*

And then hastily, because all of the sudden I feel like the boat she is on must be picking up speed, taking her to the island, like maybe I'll lose touch with her even though she's told me that's preposterous.

[Me]: *I love you*

Her message doesn't come for another two hours.

[Brooke]: *I love you too xoxoxoxo*

[Brooke]: *btw K loves the suit. things are already happening..
call u later when I get the chance*

*

I'm pretty far gone, nuts-wise, when Brooke calls me. It's twelve my time, and I am with a client. The sight of her name on my screen is impossible for me to resist. Even though my client is tearfully pressing through a nasty story of child custody arguments, I hold up a finger. "I'm so sorry," I say, and I do feel like a real shit. "I have to... I have to take this."

I leave my client in the office and tuck away in a corner down the hall.

"Brooke?" I say breathlessly into the phone.

She laughs. "Who else? Okay, listen, I only have a minute." Her voice is low, like she's trying not to be heard. "I just wanted to call you because... I don't know how long until I can again."

I don't know what to say. My heart is being squeezed again.

"Is.. uh, everything okay?"

"So much has happened," Brooke whispers. I can barely understand her. "But... yeah, okay I have to go."

I hear a woman's voice: "Heeeeyyya," and then the phone is disconnected, and the utter blank that is the end of a smartphone call hits me in the right ear.

Shaking, with excitement and something else, I go back to my office to try and finish the interview.

*

Brooke texts me only one more time. It's a torturous day and a half later.

[Brooke]: *I did it*

[Brooke]: *and I have a surprise*

[Brooke]: *be home in 2*

Two what? I wonder.

I decide not to text for clarification. I change my mind.

[Me]: *I love you. Is that 2 days?*

But I don't get a reply. I'm left to wonder what Brooke is doing, and why she isn't writing, for another torturous period of time, almost a day.

As the hours pass by, slowly, I sink into darker and darker fantasies about what she's doing. Maybe she had such a good time with Konstantin the billionaire that she's decided to stay on his island and be his mistress. And why not?

I go numb with fear when I think about my wife and how captivating she is. Surely Konstantin feels the same way about her. And the more you get to know her, the stronger the allure is.

What was I thinking? I know what Brooke was thinking, but what was *I* thinking? This was too big of a risk, and I don't stand a chance of winning.

Maybe Konstantin is terribly unattractive, I tell myself hopefully. I'm no GQ model but I'm on the average side of good-looking. There's always hope that this guy is a big, fat, bald Russian with bad breath.

Why is it that Brooke can't get in touch with me? Is she so busy fucking this guy, day and night, that she can't send a simple text message?

At last, I get a message from her:

[Brooke]: *Yes, silly two days. Now one day. See you tomorrow!*

I love you, too.

The blithe normalcy of the text shocks me.

Then I start to wonder if maybe this whole thing is just a big setup; a huge tease, a perfect execution of the game we've been playing for so long.

Would I be disappointed if that were the case?
Or would I be relieved?

*

I get the call from her while I'm in the car on the way to the courthouse. I'm thankful that I have the habit of setting up hands-free in my car, because I would probably end up wrecking the vehicle otherwise.

I answer. "Brooke."

It's more a statement of relief than anything. I don't want to admit to her that I was worried, but my voice betrays me.

"You sound... like you just saw a ghost," she says, giving me a laugh that might be described as nervous. "I'm... am I on speaker-phone?"

"The car," I say. But no one's here."

"Okay," she says. "Well, we're just clearing customs now -"

"I thought you weren't supposed to have your phone?"

"That's for plebes," she says, and I can't tell exactly how much of that is a joke. "Anyway, I'll be home soon. I... um... have a *lot* to tell you. When are you coming home?"

I grimace at my own eyes in the rear-view mirror. "A lot? Like, what? Like did you... do more than just, you know, the one time?"

She makes a sound that is a low murmur. "It's... more than just that," she says.

"What?" I stutter.

I am practically drooling onto my hands.

"Just... you'll see. When will you get home?"

"I have a court thing to file, really quick." Jennifer, my paralegal, left early with the flu and this has to be done. It *has* to be done. I can't leave it to run off and see what "surprise" my wife has for me.

"Okay, well... I'll be waiting." Brooke makes a sound into the phone like a kiss.

I drive too fast, my mind racing and my body buzzing, trying to grind through the wheels of justice as fast as I can to get home to my wife.

8: BROOKE COMES HOME

She's still in her uniform when I get home.

I'm turned on already – my cock is at Defcon 1 and I'm aware that there is probably a stain of precum seeping through at least my underwear. I haven't brought anything into the house with me, and I see that she notices this. I know my face must betray just how excruciatingly hungry I am for her right now.

To hear what she's done. This real, naughty thing she's done, and not just a story she wants me to hear.

She leans on the counter and starts to unbutton her blouse. "Well," she says. She reaches behind her and slides a pile of cash around to the edge of the counter.

It's a very, very large pile, and I start doing some calculating because, thanks to my clientele, I do know a thing or two about what \$5K looks like in twenties and hundreds. This pile has more little wrappers than it should.

Than it should.

"I must have left a really, really good impression on him," Brooke says. "Because he left me a great big tip."

She plays with the money, lifting the pile and dropping each bound stack one at a time with a little plop. One, two, three, four, five, six, seven, eight. Forty thousand dollars. In cash.

She steps toward me (I am totally paralyzed now). "So? Do you want to hear what I did to make such a good impression? Or...?"

She is unbuttoning my shirt, her lips very close to mine. The lips that almost certainly have been wrapped around another man's cock, and by the look of things, more than once.

"Or what?" I manage to say.

"Well... I told you I have a little surprise for you." She leans in and whispers in my ear, her breath hot against my skin. "But I told you I'd tell you all about it. I don't want to break the rules."

I look at her as she pulls away from my neck and stands about a foot away from me, sliding her skirt up inch by inch. "I haven't had time to take a shower yet," she says.

I look down, watching the black skirt slide over her white skin. Up, up, to the where her nylons cling to her thigh with elastic lace. Up more, until... her panties, which are not there, would ordinarily show.

"I might have done something bad on the plane," she purrs. "It was a long flight."

I reach forward, toward her snatch, and slide my hand over the smooth skin. A smear of wetness, hot and sticky, coats my palm. I dip a finger in. Brooke lets go of her skirt and grins as I explore her pussy, trying to feel for myself if she's done the very naughty thing I think she's done. I swirl my pointer finger inside of her, gauging if she's looser or not.

I've forgotten the surprise, or maybe I think this is it.

"Do you want me to shower?" Brooke asks.

I shake my head, and push her backward toward the counter. She hops at the same time I lift her onto the countertop, and she starts to helpfully wriggle her skirt back up as I get out of my pants and shirt.

I jerk her blouse open the rest of the way, and buttons spray across the tile floor with a clatter.

She has no bra on, either. I bite gently into one of her nipples, and the other hardens beneath the pads of my fingers when I do. "No bra," I say.

"Konstantin wanted me not to wear one," she says, and my cock swells anew. "He say it's easier that way."

The counter is a little too high for me to fuck her on it, I realize, so I get my cock lined up with her hole and lift her up before sitting down on a tall chair next to it. It's a swivel chair and we almost end up tipping over, but I hold her steady as her hot cunt sinks down the length of my shaft.

Brooke gives me a look. She's impressed by this maneuver.

Her pussy is soaking wet.

"Did he come in your pussy?" I ask, even though I know the answer.

Brooke looks, actually, nervous for one quick second. When my cock flexes inside of her and I give her what I hope is an encouraging look, her timidity fades.

I thrust deep into her, and her mouth falls open. "Tell me," I say.

"Oh!" she says. "Yes. Yes. I have a pussy full of cum."

I grab her hips. "Oh yeah," I say. I start to fuck her now. I'd have liked to draw this out more but I'm gripped by an all-consuming need now, and I just want to pummel my own cum into her, to get her nice and stuffed,

to reclaim her – in a way. “Is that how you earned all that money, you little whore?”

The fact that this is a true, real statement and not make-believe or just some trash you talk while fucking sends me almost over the edge right then and there.

But Brooke is there to tip me over when I manage to hold back.

She places her mouth next to my ear. “No, no. Only a little bit of it. I got the rest of it doing much, much dirtier things.”

“Like what?” I’m so close that I don’t even need her to tell me.

She leans back, hanging onto me as I bounce her up and down on my cock. She’s smiling. “Oh, you’ll see,” she says.

Nothing can hold back my climax now. I yell as I fuck my cum inside of her, as it mingles with the remnants of Konstantin’s load. She leans forward and grinds against me, driving me deep inside of her, my balls getting slick with her juices, my cum, and his. She rocks against me until she gasps and her pussy clenches around my dick.

I hold her close to me, my breath and hers mingling, our sweat running together.

For a moment I feel the fleeting hope that I felt yesterday, when I had the thought that this is all just a continuation of the game.

But there’s almost no doubt; I can feel it, and I can smell it. My wife is not telling me a story. Her cunt was already full of another man’s cum before I got to her.

I’m still inside of her when I lean back to look in her eyes.

“You okay?” I say. It’s kind of a lame question, and I don’t even know why I’m asking it exactly.

Brooke smiles. “Are you?”

My cock twitches inside of her, and her pussy responds by throbbing around me. We laugh a little.

She is, after all, right here, with me. She didn’t stay in Cyprus to become Konstantin’s mistress. She’s here, in my house, with me.

I kiss her, and ease out of her body. I put on my boxers and pants and an undershirt while she straightens out her skirt and hangs her blouse loosely over her torso.

“Well,” she says. “You want a glass of wine? And then I have something to show you.”

I want her to show it to me now, because even though I have the sated feeling of just having fucked, I can tell it won't last long.

"What is it?" I say, nodding as she holds up a bottle of wine for my approval.

She smiles. "You won't believe it. I have to show you."

She pours two glasses of wine and sets one down on the counter for me. "Patience," she says.

Patience, I think, is all I've had lately.

*

We drink half the glass of wine and then Brooke blushes a little and swirls her glass. She leads me to the bedroom. Her suitcase is there, open, and her laptop is on top of the clothes inside. Evidently, she's already used it.

She takes the laptop and climbs onto the bed. Then she pats the bed next to her and I sit down as her fingers work through some files.

It takes me a moment to understand what she's doing, but it dawns on me as soon as a green-gray light fills the screen. The shape of human bodies fills the space. I hear a laugh from the screen and Brooke taps the space-bar to stop play. She grins at me.

"What?" I say. "You filmed it?"

"*He* filmed it," Brooke says. "Micah warned me about it just before we went in. She told me she'd been suspecting it for a long time and then saw him showing the video to some other guys."

My heart skipped a beat.

"Don't worry," Brooke says. "I stole this and then I wrote over the file with another one. So... it'll just look like a bad file." She grins. "It was so James Bond of me."

My mouth falls open a little. "Huh? You mean you snuck around to get this? Won't he notice?"

Brooke smiles and shakes her head. "No he won't. I did a very clever thing. And yes, I did sneak around, and actually, I was really good at it. Anyway, he deserves it, he's a real pig for filming and not telling us. But do you want to keep talking about this, or do you want to watch?"

I take a deep breath. I'm fascinated by this aspect of the story, but my cock is leading the show right now. "Watch," I say.

Brooke tucks her feet under her. “Okay. I have to warn you, it gets a little... you know.”

I shake my head.

“Raunchy,” she says.

She looks at me, gauging my reaction.

“I like raunchy,” I say hoarsely, though part of me does have a little fear of just how raunchy that will be.

Brooke brings her thumb to her mouth and bites it. Almost like she’s deciding whether or not to believe me. “Okay,” she says, reaching forward quickly and tapping the mouse pad. “Let’s watch it then.”

I wonder if she’s seen this yet, but I can’t tear my eyes or my thoughts away from the screen to ask. As soon as I hear her voice, I’m sucked into the world playing out on the small screen.

The scene is inside. The camera, or laptop, whatever it was, is situated in a corner, with a clear view of a large, four-poster bed. Through the posters of the bed I see the door to the room, and three people (Micah, my wife, and the elusive Konstantin) coming drunkenly through the door. They stop and turn back to the hallway a few times, laughing. They’re hanging all over each other as far as I can tell.

Suddenly, the green-gray graininess of the video disappears, and the room is well-lit. It’s a richly decorated, expensive looking room, with walls of carved wood.

I can see Brooke clearly now. She’s moving her legs like she’s tipsy – coltish, unsteady walking – but her face reveals that she is searching for something in the room with a clear and sober mind. At a minimum, for that task. When she spots the camera (she looks right at it) she seems to nod, and then she turns around and puts an arm around Micah.

Konstantin is a big drunk man, a typical Slavic guy. He’s good-looking, has a bit of a belly, and a bunch of hard-looking tattoos on one arm. His accent is strong; so much so that I can hardly understand him as he joyously invites the ladies into the room and pours them drinks.

The scene plays out like a regular party for a few minutes, with everyone laughing and giggling and pouring drinks. Konstantin tells a story and the ladies laugh.

Suddenly, though, he grows serious. He pours some shots into expensive-looking crystal shot glasses from a matching crystal bottle, and hands them to the girls. Brooke, who just moments ago was laughing

girlishly, changes demeanor along with Konstantin and takes the shot nervously. Only Micah seems to still be in a jubilant mood.

“Ladies,” Konstantin says. “It’s time to get this show on the road.” He downs the drink, rubs his hands together, and rises from the chair. He moves toward the bed and bounces onto the edge of it.

Brooke looks at Micah nervously. Micah clinks her shot glass against Brooke’s. “Chin-chin.”

Micah takes a seat next to Konstantin on the bed after leaning toward Brooke to whisper something in her ear.

Brooke looks a little uncertain. She clears her throat, and sets her drink down on the cocktail table near where they were sitting. It’s low, so she has to bend her knees, and the gesture is adorably awkward.

It’s not possible to see Micah’s face, but the way she gives her head a toss and moves her hands, she seems to be giving Brooke a nod of encouragement.

“Okay,” Brooke says, and then she laughs nervously. It’s been a very, very long time since I’ve heard Brooke laugh like that, with any kind of uncertainty. Once, she lost a bet and had to sing “Bohemian Rhapsody” at a karaoke bar at the Newark train station to a bar full of rough-looking truckers. She had laughed in the same way.

And then she had nailed the song like nobody’s business.

I see that Micah is bouncing a little on the bed. She’s moving her foot in circles.

Brooke gives her hair a shake and juts her chin out. Then she slides one strap, then the other, from her dress. The slip-like cocktail dress falls right off of her slender figure.

I suck in my breath as I take in my wife’s body in her skimpy lingerie.

I feel a punch in my gut as I realize this has already happened. This is all in the past. I look over at Brooke’s face. She is absorbed by her own performance, chewing a little on her lip, as if reliving it.

When she realizes that I’m looking at her, she shifts her eyes over to me quickly and gives me the same nervous smile that she gave Micah and Konstantin.

“You look amazing,” I say. I don’t know why I feel compelled to encourage her. What’s done is done. But I think it makes her feel better. She smiles, and shifts toward me on the bed.

In the meantime, on the video, Konstantin has asked her to come closer.

“Twirl around,” he says. And then something I can’t hear well.

“What did he say?” I murmur, as I watch Konstantin brush his fingers over my wife’s ass, as though inspecting a precious object he might want to buy.

“I like to see what I’m getting,” Brooke says, her eyes on the screen.

“Stop,” Konstantin says, when Brooke is facing away from him.

I stare at the screen, and my cock slams to full-throttled life as Konstantin playfully brushes his hands over Brooke’s ass. His touch is tender, flirtatious even. I quickly look over at Brooke, and see how much she is in to watching it. When I get back to the screen, Konstantin has his fingers under the flared lace at the back of Brooke’s lingerie.

He pulls it out, away from her skin. Even in the video I catch a glimpse of Brooke’s bare snatch. I wonder if she was wet when he did this; if he caught the scent of her sweet pussy and enjoyed it as much as I do.

I hear a snap and the lingerie slaps against Brooke’s snatch as he releases it. I see the muscles of her back ripple.

He puts his hands on her ass, one palm cradling each buttock, and works his fingers up and under her lingerie. He pulls her toward him, and buries his face between her legs, his mouth – though not visible – clearly against the material of her panties.

“I could feel his breath all over my pussy then,” Brooke says, and my balls feel like coals in a fire.

Konstantin mumbles something into my wife’s snatch. I start to look to Brooke for the translation, when, in the video, she bends over. No translation needed.

Konstantin jerks on the lingerie and pulls it away to the left, so Brooke’s pussy is exposed to the two of them. Then, like a flash, he reaches for Micah’s hair and pushes her toward Brooke’s exposed cunt.

There is no way to see the details, just the back of Micah’s head with Konstantin’s hand in it, bobbing up and down as she laps at Brooke’s cunt. Konstantin has turned his head so I can see the greedy expression as he watches Micah exploring her pussy. I try to imagine the view, the pink tongue of another woman slipping into Brooke’s sweet folds. My stomach clenches and my cock drips with precum.

Brooke – real Brooke, next to me – slides her hand over my thigh and reaches for the shape of my cock. I catch her hand and squeeze it. “Just... uh... wait...” I mumble. If she touches me now, I’ll be a goner before we even get to the good part. Whatever that is.

This goes on for a while. There is a barely audible sticky sound, the sound of Micah licking. Then I hear Brooke’s breathy moans, then a squeak. Konstantin pushes Micah’s face into my wife’s ass further and Brooke’s squeaks and makes a sound like she’s coming.

“Was she that good?” I ask.

Brooke just looks at me and gives me her mystery smile. “It... um... well, just wait,” she says. Then quickly she adds “Do you like this? It kind of got... you know. Out of my control.”

My mouth hangs open. “It’s... hot...” I say.

My eyes are on the screen now. Konstantin has released Micah’s hair and pushed her onto the bed. He’s dipping his hand into my wife’s cunt while grabbing handful’s of Micah’s tits. He orders Brooke to stand up and get out of her lingerie, which I see is stretched beyond repair when she does. Then he turns to Micah and must tell her to scoot back on the bed, because that’s what she does.

Brooke turns to face them now, and her hair is mussed and wet, like her skin. She looks flushed and strangely satisfied, though maybe this all just from bending over and standing up suddenly. She looks on at the scene in front of her with mild concern.

Like she didn’t know where it was going.

Konstantin takes out his cock. It’s a thick and impressive specimen, though not extremely long. It’s hard and seems almost gnarled by the veins that wrap around it and are bulging through his foreskin. He wastes no time waddling up the bed, toward the camera and toward Micah’s face.

I watch, almost forgetting about Brooke for a moment, as Micah’s tongue flicks up from her mouth and laps at his balls and the length of his cock. He drops down and rubs the length of his shaft over her lips.

He lifts his shaft up and lets it fall onto her mouth with a slap. Again and again, while Micah moans and twists on the bed. Then he grabs her hair and lifts her slightly from the bed. His cock fills her mouth, and he starts to face-fuck her.

Micah is making a glug-glug sound as Konstantin thrusts into her open mouth. It’s really a porn-grade scene. My cock is swollen to near-

bursting as I watch it, but I can't help feeling a little nervous for what's to come. Will Brooke let herself be used like a whore the same way?

Suddenly Konstantin drops Micah's hair, pulling back on it to tilt her head up. I can see that she has her mouth open, her lips turned up in a welcoming smile. Konstantin grabs his cock, jerking at it furiously.

Ropes of cum splurge out and all over Micah's face.

I feel a drop of disappointment. That was good, and all, but...

I look over at Brooke, who rubs her lips together. "There's more," she says hoarsely.

Konstantin falls to the side and lies down, reclining on one arm. He says something that's barely audible, and I see Brooke flinch a little. Then he laughs. "Oh, we're far from done yet my little plum. Do it."

He rests his head on his hand smugly and watches, as I watch, as Brooke climbs uncertainly onto the bed.

Micah takes the lead, rising up to meet her. "Do it," Konstantin says, with an encouraging voice.

Brooke leans in and pauses, while Micah licks her lips. Then my wife extends her tongue, and begins to lick Konstantin's cum off of Micah's face. Her tongue is bright and pink. She begins timidly, making darting little flicks across her cheeks and her lips. But then she starts to get into it, lapping the cum up with licks more like a dog's, her tongue flat and wet. She moves down her neck to get a long strand of cum that is dripping down to Micah's tits.

Micah starts to kiss Brooke in return, and for a moment they're just making out. I can see their tongues darting in and out of each other's mouths in wet flashes of pink. I almost forget that Konstantin is there, enjoying his show.

In real life, I let out a sigh to release the tension. Brooke looks over at me again, and slides her hand toward my cock. "You sure?" she says flirtatiously.

I look back at the screen. "How much more of this is left?" I struggle to say.

Brooke smiles. "A lot. And it's really dirty."

I'm watching Brooke onscreen, exploring Micah's body with her hands and flicking her tongue against Micah's in a display intended to evoke cunnilingus. Behind them, Konstantin's greedy eyes watch with delight.

“No,” I groan. “I want to watch it.”

Brooke flips onto her stomach. “Suit yourself,” she says cheerfully.

On screen, Konstantin’s voice rumbles over the sticky flicks of the girls’ tongues. “Okay ladies. Let’s get me ready to go again.”

The women turn toward him, and he rises up on his knees, his cock hard already, twitching a little as it thickens to full readiness.

Micah doesn’t hesitate to lean over and grab his shaft in one hand while opening her mouth to get him inside. She has to contort her body a little, but the view from the camera angle is spectacular. Her ass is decorated by a lacy thong and I can just see the bulge of Konstantin’s cock in her cheek. Puffing it out, deflating, over and over again while she works hard to suck him off.

He’s looking, however, at my wife. He reaches up a hand and sticks his fingers in her mouth. Brooke opens for him and sucks on his fore- and middle fingers. Konstantin pulls her jaw open, as though sizing up her ability to get his girth into her mouth.

Micah lets go of his cock and rises up. As if there is some kind of choreography at work, Brooke doesn’t miss a beat. She lowers her head and twists, as Micah did, to begin sucking his cock. I’m treated to a similar view on the opposite side of her body, except she’s naked. And this time, as his cock puffs out her cheeks, Konstantin slides his hand down to dip between her legs and gropes her pussy and between her ass cheeks.

They take turns sucking him off, but Konstantin is more interested in exploring Brooke’s body with his hands. When Micah takes her turn sucking his dick, he fucks Brooke’s mouth with his fingers or grabs a handful of her breasts.

I can see Brooke is turned on by what he’s doing. She rolls her body in waves of pleasure before lowering her head to suck enthusiastically on his dick.

Konstantin changes his tack, suddenly, and pulls Micah by the hair up to his face. He whispers something in her ear that makes her purr, and then Micah slings an arm over Brooke and licks her earlobe before whispering into her ear.

I see Brooke in the video look a little disturbed by whatever the suggestion is.

“What’d they say?” I say to the real Brooke, who is watching, fascinated, next to me.

She looks up at me. "You'll see."

"No?" Konstantin is saying on the video. He puts a finger under Brooke's chin and whispers in her ear.

Brooke seems to be thinking something over, and then she shakes her head slightly. Konstantin says something in a low voice, and she smiles in return. Nods. She agrees to whatever it is.

Micah smiles and turns on to her hands and knees. Konstantin pushes her slightly around, and I can assume he's trying to get the best camera angle he can, because I have an excellent view of her ass and his cock once they are in place.

Konstantin slides his fingers into Micah's pussy, and then up to her pink eyelet. He sweeps his fingers over her ass, and then holds her buttocks open to spit onto it. He looks at Brooke, who demurs for a moment before pushing her hair from her face and leaning over Micah.

I can no longer see what's happening, but it's obvious that Brooke is licking Micah's butt hole.

I look at her.

She shrugs. "He told me to get her ready. One of us had to... you know, take it. And the other had to... you'll see." Then she makes a face. "Too much?"

I make a noise and shake my head.

"That's it," Konstantin says, pushing Brooke's hair from her face so he has a better view of her tongue as it explores Micah's puckered hole.

He pushes Brooke down, under Micah's legs, and at the same time stuffs a pillow underneath her head. Brooke shifts into position while I squint at the scene, trying to picture what he has planned.

Konstantin dips his cock into Micah's pussy and gets it wet, then lifts it up to her eyelet and presses it against her pucker. That's when I see what Brooke's job is: to lick at his dangling balls while he fucks Micah's ass.

"Oh!" Micah squeals, when Konstantin pushes inside of her. He's going at her from kind of an angle, so that the camera captures the length of his shaft sinking into her until he gets in deep. And I also have a view of Brooke, her neck straining as she tilts her head back and up to extend her tongue to Konstantin's balls.

Konstantin shifts, throwing a leg over Brooke, and drives himself deep into Micah's ass. He drops a hand to pull on Brooke's face up to his

balls. I can only see Brooke's lips against his taint; she has taken his whole sac in her mouth.

Micah is trying to rock against him and moaning. She whips her hair around to look back at Konstantin. "Oh!" she says. "I want you to fuck me!"

Konstantin responds by bouncing my wife's head beneath his cock, and wiggling his hips side to side, all while Brooke holds his balls in her mouth.

She releases him when he mumbles something at her. And then he starts fucking Micah hard in the ass, slamming into her. His balls slap Brooke in the chin and she tries to lick them at each pass.

He's fucking Micah so hard that the slaps against her ass can be heard over her moans and squeals. He fucks her for a long, long time, probably because it's his second fuck, and I stare in abject despair and elation as Brooke lets him slap her face, lips and tongue with his hairy balls. She probably laps at Micah's pussy as well, and I am certain Micah's juices are dripping down onto her face and lips.

Konstantin growls and thrusts hard into Micah, grabbing her hips and jamming his cock deep inside of her. He dumps his seed into her ass, looking up at the ceiling and yelling a bunch of things in another language.

When he pulls his cock out of Micah, it slaps down on Brooke's face. He slides it over her lips and her throat, leaving a trail of his cum all over her. He leans back and off to the side, and waves his hand at Brooke.

Micah stays in position, and Brooke hesitantly rolls up and onto her own hands and knees behind Micah.

"Push it open," I hear Konstantin say. "I want a good look."

Brooke looks back at him, shifts on the bed, and places her palms on Micah's ass. She spreads her open, and Micah's swollen asshole gapes wide, Konstantin's cum oozing from her hole.

"This is the, uh... intense part," Brooke says.

I look at her briefly. She has a flush of excitement on her face – I can tell because she's staring right at the screen with her eyes bright.

When I look back to the screen, Brooke of the porno flick is already busy. Leaning down to Micah's ass, her jaw moving, her lips pressed up close to her skin.

"Did you eat her *out*?" I say.

Brooke rubs her face. "It was for twenty thousand dollars," she says.

I suppose this is a “yes.” I watch the screen, my mind filling in the details I cannot see: Brooke’s tongue dipping into the cum-filled hole where Konstantin had just hammered Micah. Sucking his cum out of her friend’s ass.

Konstantin murmurs with approval, but he isn’t a spectator for long. He reaches for my wife’s pussy and begins to play with it. She’s wet, so his fingers slide into her cunt easily. He toys with her clit and finger-fucks her, while he tells her to keep going. “Get her all squeaky-clean,” he says.

I look at Brooke. I wonder if she enjoys this kind of filthy, lewd sex and demeaning talk, or if it was all just for money. Or maybe a little bit of both.

Konstantin starts to play with Brooke’s ass, running his finger over her hole and drawing her pussy juices up to it.

Brooke breaks with Micah’s ass and turns to look at him sharply. She shifts her butt away from him.

He holds up his hands. “All right, all right,” he says. Evidently they’ve made some kind of agreement.

But he’s not done trying. “I could pay extra,” he offers.

Brooke smiles, but she shakes her head.

Konstantin reclines on the bed and snaps his fingers at Micah, who obligingly comes to sit next to him on her hands and knees. Brooke falls onto her heels and waits, her hands on her knees, like an obedient pet.

Micah leans over to Brooke and licks the cum that dribbled all over her neck and lips off.

Incredibly, Konstantin's cock is twitching back to life.

Micah leans over his cock and he pulls her down to suck him off. She licks all the cum from his dick. She swirls her tongue around his shaft, licks him from top to bottom from all different angles, and then takes him all inside of her again and slowly sucks every last lingering bit of cum from his shaft.

He snaps his fingers again, and my wife starts to climb on top of him.

“No, no,” he says. “Other way.”

Brooke turns around, and lowers herself onto Konstantin’s dick, reverse cowgirl. I hear a slap, and see that he’s smacked her rear. She starts to buck on top of him, and he gives her another swat. “Ride me!” he says.

Her breasts bounce as she starts to pop up and down on Konstantin. He has his hands on her ass, and he’s kneading her bottom, his hands

working at her flesh lewdly.

Brooke keeps bouncing, and while she is, Micah reclines on the bed and watches the scene with her head next to Brooke's ass. She reached around and works her fingers into Brooke's pussy, playing with her as she rides Konstantin's cock.

Brooke starts to pant and gasp, and she sounds like she's going to come. She throws her head back and grasps Micah's wrist, but I can't tell if it's to stop her or to keep her there, doing whatever she's doing to her pussy.

"Oh my God!" she shouts, and spit flies from her mouth as she comes. She starts to fall forward, abandoning her frantic humping of Konstantin.

He pushes her forward, and she shudders and rattles as she crumples into a sort of ball with her ass up in his direction. He sits up and slides out from under her, getting onto his knees, and that's when I realize he's plunged a thumb into her ass.

Brooke wiggles uncomfortably, and I see she's saying, "Oh, no, no, no, I can't, it's too big."

Micah moves around to rest Brooke's head on her lap and whispers something in her ear. Brooke's eyes fly open and she looks, almost in the direction of the camera, almost vacantly.

Konstantin leans back and to the left, and gets something from off-camera. When he gets back on camera, he has a tube of lubrication in his hand.

"What'd she say," I say breathlessly.

Brooke smiles and holds up a finger.

Micah holds out her hand and Konstantin squirts some lube into it, and then he dribbles some on the length of his own cock. He rubs it all over himself while he watches Micah. She reaches over Brooke's body and slips two fingers into Brooke's ass. She does it quickly.

Brooke's eyes widen and she makes a face. "It's too big," she repeats.

Micah moves the very tips of her fingers quickly in and out of Brooke's ass while she strokes her hair with her other hand. "You can do it," she says.

Konstantin is enjoying his view, stroking his cock, and he lets Micah finger-fuck Brooke's ass for a bit.

"Okay, okay," he says, pushing Micah's hand away.

He places the fat end of his cock against Brooke's ass.

Brooke pushes up to her hands and knees. Micah scoots back and smooths her hair. She leans down and says something to her and Brooke lies back down with her chest on the bed. Micah climbs over Brooke's head and puts her hands on her ass, pulling it apart for Konstantin, and simultaneously keeping Brooke from sitting up again.

Brooke's eyes, which I can see over Micah's calf, are wide and seem to have hollowed out. She's in another place, concentrating on something else, as Konstantin slowly pushes forward. Pushing his fat prick into her ass.

Her mouth opens slightly, and for a moment I think she's going to make a sound. The inches of his dick disappear inside of her, until at last he presses his thighs against her rear. Micah bites his nipples, still holding Brooke's ass open for him.

And then he begins to fuck her, while Micah watches his cock plunging in and out of my wife.

It's a long fuck, and no wonder. He's come so many times already. Brooke slides her hands beneath her chest and up to her pussy, to play with her clit, though I can barely see what she's doing because they've shifted so much on the bed.

At last, Konstantin groans and pushes Micah away to grab Brooke by the hips and slam his cock into her with hard thrusts.

Brooke squeals and pushes up onto her hands and knees, throwing her head back and letting him ram her until at last he yells and dumps his load of cum into her ass.

I am almost doubled over on the bed now from the pain in my cock.

On screen, the threesome are panting and start giggling and collapsing onto each other.

"Is that it?" I manage to say.

Brooke grins. "For the video," she says. She climbs up toward me and puts her hands on my shoulders. "Was it too much? I can't believe I did that." She looks a little worried and then reaches behind her to turn off the computer.

I'm dumbfounded, so I just shake my head.

"It's... I didn't know you were... into that.."

I need to be inside of her, *now*. My head is reeling from what I've just seen, and I'm looking at the woman perched on my lap like she's a

completely different person, but I have never needed release as much as I need it right now.

Brooke shifts on my lap, and slides her hands down to my pants. She unbuttons me. "I'm a little embarrassed, now that I watch it... but..." she lifts her eyes. I can only concentrate on the feeling of her sliding my belt through the buckle, her fingers grazing my stiff cock through the material of my pants. "He offered me *so much money* for it."

I stare at her. Now I really don't know her.

For second I feel like I've been thrown into another world. Back where we were just a few weeks ago, when this was all a game. And Brooke is just playing it so much better than usual.

Then it slams into me:

This is real.

My wife really did let a guy fuck her in the ass.

For money.

She slides off of me and brings me up to standing with her, so she can slide my pants off of me. I take off my shirt while she slips her skirt down her legs. I'm immediately struck by the scent of her pussy, overpowering with the scent of my cum.

And Konstantin's.

Her excitement is slick on the insides of her thighs.

My wife not only let a guy fuck her in the ass, she *liked* it.

She pushes me gently backward and climbs onto my lap. I feel her smooth pussy slipping and sliding over my cock, and my dick flexes hard. But she remains elusive, even as I'm rendered unable to speak or do anything but wait for her to give me what I want.

It's clear that we're on her terms, here.

I hold her hips, and she keeps rolling over me while she whispers close to my mouth, my ear, over my carotid artery: "At first I just did it for the money," she says. "But I think... I actually liked it."

She looks down when my cock spasm against her legs.

"I hope you don't mind that I let him fill my ass up again after that."

She grins when my cock reacts violently to her words. "I guess you don't," she purrs.

I want to hear what else she did, I really do, but I can't take the teasing anymore. I lift her by her hips and position her sopping hole over

my cock. Brooke seems to delight in this, and she throws her head back when I thrust inside of her.

I want her to ride my cock like she did for Konstantin, but I'm so overwhelmed by the feel of her hot cunt around me that I can't form the words. I bounce her with one hand, and I reach around her to her ass, the video images fresh in my mind.

Her pussy juices have smeared up into the valley between her buttocks and she's wet and slimy all over. I slide my fingers into her butt crack and down to where my shaft is buried in her cunt, and back up, over the rough circle of her anus.

I slip a finger into her ass as she's bouncing, and I slide right in. The inside of her ass is hot and velvety, not at all what I'd expected. She bounces and moans, and her tits jiggle in my face.

I'd love to talk dirty to her, or drag this on, but I only have to think about any of the images I just saw to put me over the edge. I try to fight them, but they hit me in a flurry: Konstantin licking her pussy, Brooke sucking cum out of Micah's ass, Konstantin's balls in her mouth... and I explode in her pussy.

*

We lie in the now-dark room afterward.

I'm stunned. I can't get the images of my wife with Konstantin out of my head.

"What?" Brooke says, finally, walking her fingers over my chest.

I don't answer, just sigh, and I know this is going to set her off.

I'm actually sighing because I know I'm going to have to talk about what's bothering me, and I feel a little bit like a shit.

"Tell me," Brooke coos in my ear. Then she rolls onto her back. "No, don't. You're upset that I went too far."

I sigh again.

"It isn't that," I say.

There's a silence.

"Okay... look, I'm sorry," I say, rolling onto my elbow. "I don't want to be upset about it, because it was part of our agreement. You... didn't, you know, break any rules or anything. I just, um... I guess I just can't help but be... out of sorts I guess because... I mean, Brooke. It was so.... *Extreme*."

Brooke's face looks odd. Maybe it's the light in the room, which is nothing more than an outside porch light coming through the window and a nightlight from the bathroom coming around the corner. Her eyes are luminous, gray and large, and her lips are dark.

"I know," she says. "I just got... carried away."

I wonder if I dare to ask.

"By what?" I ask. I push her hair from her face. "What did you get carried away by?"

Brooke laughs lightly. "Not by *him*, if that's what you're worried about." She rolls her eyes. Then she touches my face, and her expression changes to a tender one. "No... God, not by him. He's a real asshole. No, just... you know, the parties, the drugs, the glamour. And the money. I admit. All of that."

The drugs. I decide not to dwell on that.

"So what else did you do," I ask her. "All week?"

Brooke shrugs. "Sat on the beach. Slept in with a hangover. Went shopping." She leans toward me. "He bought me a really slinky dress."

My abdomen spasms. I don't like the idea of this guy shopping for my wife, dressing her up.

I'm still bothered by something. It isn't so much the sex. It's something else.

I put a hand out to her face and pull her close to me. I kiss her mouth again, tenderly, possessively.

She kisses me back, and holds my wrist. "What?" she says, when she pulls away for a moment to breathe. She reads my eyes and then shifts backward to get a better look. "You're not worried about this, are you?"

"I don't know," I say, trying to sound like I'm playing it cool. "He seems like an okay-looking guy, and he has all this money. Parties, shopping, lying around on the beach. You're sure you don't want that?"

Brooke is taken aback. She moves back on the pillow and looks at me. "You're serious," she says. "Are you?"

I shrug.

Brooke puts her forehead against mine. "You're crazy," she says. "I'm here, right?"

I nod. She works her fingers down toward my cock.

"It was always about the money," she says. "And the game."

Her fingers are playing with my dick, which is coming back to life in spite of my doubts.

“Anyway,” she says. “I’m not flying for them again, I don’t think.”

She closes her hand around my cock.

“No?” I say. “Why not?”

I pull her leg up and over my hips, and we kiss.

“Well... with all the extras I put in, I think I made enough to finish out the year and be done.”

She melts into my body, and her hand strokes my cock in rhythm with her lips on my mouth.

“Unless...” she says, seductively. “You think I should take another flight?”

I am powerless to stop my cock from flexing in her hand.

EPILOGUE

I sit down in my favorite seat. It faces the dim entrance to the bar, and because it's on the rounded corner of the u-shape, no one seems to want to sit next to me.

The bartender knows me by now. He does one of those nods where guys lift their chins up sharply in greeting. "Dewar's?"

I nod.

The bar is bustling today. I always wonder what the deal is with this place: sometimes it's dead, sometimes a Tuesday feels like a Friday at a hot club downtown. I've never been able to pick up on the pattern.

I wonder what the bartender thinks of me. Just another businessman, boinking a stewardess?

Whatever it is, he couldn't possibly have the truth sorted out, and I enjoy having that secret.

I like to get here early when I can. The anticipation builds and builds, into a sweet ache.

Brooke arrives, neat and tidy, her skirt impeccable, her blouse buttoned up and her tie just-so. She's alone, and she wheels up with her ruthlessly efficient walk.

She grins. "Fancy meeting you here," she purrs.

"Want a drink?" I ask. I honestly am not sure if she's coming or going.

She shakes her head slowly.

Then she leans in, and places her mouth close to my ear.

"But I *do* have a story for *you*."

I slam my drink, and I pay the bill with an extra-large tip for the bartender. Jim, I think his name is. Sometimes I forget to pay him, but he purports not to mind because he knows I'll be back.

I follow my wife out the doors, toward the elevators. She has a room. She can afford to get one for a few hours.

This is the new game. It's kind of like the old one, but with a twist.

She has stories for me, just like before.

She hits the elevator button and turns to look at me. "It has to be really quick," she mouths.

Now, though, sometimes the stories aren't made-up.

Me? I guess I'm just glad that she keeps coming back to me to tell them.

This is the last week she's going to fly. She starts school in the spring.

We step into the elevator. I look over at Brooke, the woman I married with the captivating upturned corner of her mouth, always hiding a secret. I think my gamble paid off, in the end, because now I have the answer to the question. Will she come back to me, if she can go anywhere in the world?

So far, so good.

My stomach lurches as the elevator starts to rise.

Away we go.

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APOLOGY!

Due to a glitch in the Amazon system, I've had to remove direct hyperlinks from my backmatter. I apologize for any inconvenience this causes my readers. Any of these titles can be located on [My Author Page](#)

*Hotwife **Suspense** By Arnica Butler*

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It began with a chance encounter with a man from his wife's past. Rich knew Tennile had some skeletons – of a sexual nature – in her closet, but he never dreamed they were going to come back to haunt them both. Before he can blink, the two of them are embroiled in high-stakes intrigue, with Tennile's reputation and career, their marriage, and a lot of money on the line. There seems to be no way out but to play the game, and Tennile's past might be game-winning asset. In the style of *A Well-Laid Trap*, this is a thrilling hotwife ride that will keep you hooked until the end.

[A Well-Laid Trap](#)

It all begins when Patrick is convinced he saw his wife with another man at a downtown bar.

He begins to investigate. But the more Patrick uncovers about Jordan's activities, the less he understands.

The biggest problem is, Patrick can't decide how he really feels. On the one hand, his wife seems to be betraying him, and on the other, his sex life has reached a scorching pinnacle he never thought possible.

But he had better hold on to his hat, because when he finds out the truth, things will get much, much hotter than he might have ever imagined...

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In Megyn's view, nothing could be sillier than entering a charity contest to win a "date" with the sexy black celebrity Max Riley, not even to raise money for underprivileged youth. (Un)fortunately for her, her friend entered her in the contest anyway.

When she wins, her husband Peter sees a chance to dip into a fantasy of his. But when this brush with fate turns into a very real, permanent job offer for Megyn - one that puts her in close and frequent contact with the famed black actor - the couple has a lot more to think about than just a winning a "date."

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Mike is on his friends' luxury sailboat with his stunning blond wife Claudia, hoping for nothing more than to convince Claudia that sailing is enjoyable. It turns out that his friends are swingers, in the Caribbean for more than just

the sailing. And it turns out that Claudia has a streak of voyeurism in her. The couple embark on a mild adventure of exploration and sexual reawakening on the warm, beautiful beaches of the Caribbean, and it seems like the ideal vacation.

Grand Slam: An Interracial Hotwife Adventure

Charles keeps a secret desire about his wife Zoe. Her sizzling beauty is typically hidden under scrubs and a hair bun, so his fantasy may never happen. But a wrong turn on a weekend getaway turns out to be the opening pitch of a very naughty game, and Zoe seems determined to knock it out of the park.

The Tenant: A Very Naughty Hotwife Novel

Once upon a time, his exotic and incredibly sexy wife Anna loved to indulge Brian's fantasies...to a point. She teased strangers, and took them to cruel, tantalizing places. But she never went all the way. The game ended when Brian and Anna got married, and that was that.

Or was it?

When the gorgeous, charming, and very black John moves into their basement rental, Brian finds that his sleeping desires have been building up all these years. He doesn't just want Anna to tease. He isn't just toying with the idea. He is obsessed with driving his wife to do things with another man. Lewd things. Obscene things.

When he confesses his desires, is Anna just a little bit too willing to make things just like old times? Is she too easy to push over each new line? Brian can't help but wonder if his own obsessions have gone too far...or if Anna's have.

Not Black And White

When a photographer turns Rick on to the idea of watching his wife with another man, Rick feels an obsessive desire inside of himself catch fire. He

can't help arrange for his shy, girl-next-door wife Danielle and the rugged, black photographer to cross paths. He knows that Drake Reyes' erotic photographs are not as abstract as they appear, and that Reyes sleeps with his married models. He knows his wife is not immune to Reyes' charms – no one is. He just can't help but imagine what it would be like to stand in his gallery, looking at Reyes' lurid photos, knowing his own wife is the model, knowing how the photos were taken. But was it really his idea, or have Drake and Danielle been as manipulative as he has?

Please note, this is the novelized version of the short story Black and White, with significant changes to all scenes depicted in the short story, as well as the point of view. There is, however, some repetition: scenarios which occurred in the short occur in the novel. There are plenty of fresh new adult scenes, however. Please enjoy.

Unlocking Noel: A Reluctant Hotwife Novel

Pretty, bookish Noel is not exactly an adventurer in or out of the bedroom, and Spencer has come to accept that. But things take an unexpected turn one year at an annual ski vacation. When they return the following year, Spencer gets to work on unlocking Noel and her (literally) dark desires.

A romantic hotwife novel with a deliciously corruptible and reluctant heroine.

Fun Summer Swinger Titles:

A Summer Vacation

Poor Keith. He's been condemned to a campy cruise with his family and friends. Worse yet, he suspects something is going on between his wife and bad-boy Hank, the husband of a family friend his wife has invited along. Keith's in for a very big surprise – and much more naughty, adult fun than he expected on this cruise – when he finds out what's really going on.

Try To Have Some Fun

Helena and Steve's wealthy, sexy, swinger friends have returned to town. Helena has a child- and work-free stretch of summer ahead of her. There's nothing stopping her from spending her days relaxing by their spectacular pool. No reason not to borrow a tiny bikini, or to maybe sunbathe topless.

Or skinny-dip at one of their wild parties.

One thing, though, will probably lead to another...

Romantic Hotwife Books By Arnica:

Ela's Performance

Peter's sweet-faced and fiery wife is headed back to school for a degree in violin performance. Unexpectedly, Peter finds himself becoming very paranoid about who Ela is spending so much time with, and what she is doing at school so very late. It isn't as if he doesn't have his reasons for suspicion. There's the way his own relationship with Ela started, and their own past experiment with an open relationship before they were married. A few other strange things to fuel his jealous fantasies...

And when he discovers someone from Ela's past has resurfaced, he'll take a chance and confront his own desires and obsessions...but will he get what he really wants?

The Houseguest

Sharing and temptation...and sharing temptation. An old buddy returns to Erik's hometown, down on his luck and getting a divorce. By offering to let Ethan stay with them, Erik sees a way to get closer to making his wife-sharing fantasies a reality. To his delight, Natalie seems to be game for something far more adventurous than ever before. But as things heat up, Erik can't help but wonder: Who's seducing whom?

A Conventional Hotwife

Paul Banks was thrilled when a luggage mix-up five years ago opened a window of opportunity for his long-buried desires. Since that time, he and his wife have been playing a little game at their yearly company conventions, and every year his wife ups the ante, going further into his fantasies. But Kathy Banks might be getting just a bit out of control, and things might be going a little too far...

Or not.

The Hotwife Summer

When Ben and Summer have the chance to spend the summer in Italy, their stale marriage starts to heat up in ways Ben could only have dreamed about. Summer is ready to take his hotwife fantasy all the way, and her choice is a sexy, Italian, Michelin star-studded chef. It's too late to put the brakes on what he's set in motion when Ben discovers the humiliating truth about Summer's choice of man. Summer has a taste for being naughty, and a filthy little plan of her own. Will it be everything he could wish for, or will Ben's cuckold fantasy turn into a nightmare he can't escape?

Body of Research

When ever-suspicious Chris plays private detective on his wife's phone and finds that she uses dozens of dating apps, he worries that his darkest fantasies have come true. And it may not be as delicious as he had imagined.

It turns out that Jen is up to something other than cheating, and the door is open for the two of them to explore the boundaries of their marriage. But in any experiment, the results can be unexpected...

The Hobby Job

Former career professional Laura is going crazy living her stay-at-home-mom life in a small country town. Her husband Conrad has the perfect solution: get a “hobby job.” Laura gets turned on to the idea, and to

Conrad's surprise, chooses to wait tables at a run-down restaurant down the street. But she gets a lot more than a hobby job when she meets Nate, a young, hot waiter who has his eyes on her from the start.

Conrad and Laura start on separate journeys, exploring new possibilities in their marriage, and opening up to their hidden desires, fantasies, and needs. Will their journeys merge, or will Laura's "hobby job" make a hobby of their marriage?

The Hotwife Tattoo

When Greg's brother marries his wild, tattooed, ex-girlfriend Renee, he knows things will be a little complicated. But when Renee befriends his wife Sara, she starts to change in almost unbelievable ways. Greg sees that there is something more to Renee's plans than just friendly sister-in-law bonding. Is Renee's influence all bad, or can Greg get something he has always wanted and never admitted to is wife – maybe even himself?

*Explore **darker** themes by Arnica Butler:*

Well-Constructed Affairs

As a hot female construction engineer, John's wife Adria draws a lot of attention at the job site. Which isn't all bad. But when Adria opens the door for him to tell her about his sexual fantasies, he doesn't realize she has opened the door on her own – very dark – fantasy as well. A fantasy she hasn't shared with anyone until now. The couple are off on an exploration of their desires...but is their marriage well-constructed enough to withstand the forces of their fantasies?

Nikita Gets In Too Deep

When Cole and his wife Nik arrive at their usual vacation spot in dull Cape Breton, they're taken by surprise by the most unlikely of next-door neighbors: ultra-sexy Paige and wealthy, commanding Mitch. And these

new neighbors are full of surprises. Cole and Nik embark on new adventures in their marriage, trying new things and pushing boundaries they'd never even discussed. It's invigorating, but Cole can't help but wonder if his transformed wife hasn't gotten herself in too deep...

A Gamble: The Making of A Hotwife

Ryan is just an average guy, coaxing his sweet, beautiful wife Victoria into playing into his hotwife fantasy – even if they're just pretending. But a trip to Vegas with his co-worker Brad and his sexy wife Irena turns Ryan's life upside-down. To help Ryan, Brad makes a proposal that could change everything...but it all centers on Victoria's innocence. How far will Victoria go to save what she holds most dear, now that her virtues, her love for Ryan, their marriage, Ryan's desires, and even their finances all hang in the balance? This is a 52,000-word novel about risk and romance, filled to the brim with the hard, steamy scenes you love. Please enjoy!

A Dark Place: Cuckolded In Lagos

Three people are carving out their fortunes in Africa's largest city, but each of them holds a deeper, darker desire. What is the secret desire of the angelic Charlotte, who finds all men's eyes on her after dark in Lagos? What about Andrew, who keeps a secret hunger so buried perhaps he doesn't admit it even to himself? And what could be darker than Clement Ambode's already shadowy “*reliability*” as an all-purpose contractor in the underbelly of Lagos?

Charlotte, Andrew, and Clement will find themselves in a very dark place when their worlds collide in this ultra-sexy, novella-length cuckold story.